Aquifer Open Study Notes

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This resource has been adapted into multiple languages, including English, Tok Pisin, Arabic (عربي), French (Français), Hindi (हिंदी), Indonesian (Bahasa Indonesia), Portuguese (Português), Russian (Русский), Spanish (Español), Swahili (Kiswahili), and Simplified Chinese (简体中文).

Ezekiel

Ezekiel 1:1

- In the thirtieth year: Priests began their service in the temple in Jerusalem when they were 30 years old. Ezekiel was a priest (see Ezekiel 1:3). However, he was living with the Judean exiles in Babylon. Because he was far from Jerusalem, he could not serve in the temple in the usual way.

Ezekiel's identity as a priest in exile is important for understanding his message. The exiles felt separated from God and from the normal ways of worshiping him in the temple. In the ancient world, people often believed that their gods were closely connected to specific lands. So those who were taken away from the promised land could easily think that the Lord no longer cared about them.
But God's word came to Ezekiel while he was in Babylon. This showed that God had not forgotten his people. It also showed that God still had plans and a future for them.

- The Kebar River was probably a large irrigation canal near Nippur, southeast of Babylon. The Babylonians had removed the earlier residents because they supported Assyria. Then they settled other exiles in that region, including people from Judah.

The Babylonians usually moved people in groups and allowed them to keep their ethnic identity. The Assyrians followed a different policy. They scattered people among many nations to weaken them. Because the Babylonians kept groups together, the people of Judah were later able to return to their homeland. Those from the northern kingdom, who had been exiled earlier by the Assyrians, did not return in the same way.

Ezekiel 1:1–3

The opening verses show that the prophet began his ministry among the exiles from Judah. The Babylonians had taken these people away from their land and brought them to Babylon.

Ezekiel 1:1–3.27

Old Testament prophetic books often begin with a "call narrative." A call narrative describes how God chose and sent a prophet to serve in this role (for example, Jeremiah 1:4–19).

This account showed that the prophet's message was legitimate. It made clear that the prophet spoke as the Lord's ambassador (a representative sent with authority). The call narrative also introduced important themes that the book would explain more fully later.

In Ezekiel, the call narrative focuses on the Lord's coming judgment on his people.

Ezekiel 1:2

it was the fifth year of the exile of King Jehoiachin: The word of the Lord first came to Ezekiel in 593 BC. At that time, Judah was still partly independent (see Ezekiel Book Introduction, "Setting"). However, the Babylonians had already taken control of the nation in 597 BC. They had carried King Jehoiachin away into exile in Babylon.

Jehoiachin's uncle, Zedekiah, ruled Judah as a vassal of Babylon from 597 to 586 BC. A vassal was a king who ruled under the authority of a stronger king. Ezekiel dated his prophecy from the time of Jehoiachin's captivity, not from the reign of Zedekiah. He likely viewed Zedekiah as a temporary ruler in place of the rightful king, Jehoiachin.

Later, Zedekiah rebelled against King Nebuchadnezzar of Babylon (2 Kings 24:20). In response, Nebuchadnezzar attacked Jerusalem in 588 BC. He destroyed the city and burned the temple in 586 BC.

Ezekiel 1:3

Ezekiel was a priest by birth. He was also a prophet because the hand of the Lord was upon him. This means that God had chosen him and given him authority.

Priests offered sacrifices in the temple and taught God's law to the people. Prophets delivered God's messages of blessing or judgment. They also prayed to God on behalf of the people.

Ezekiel's ministry included both of these roles. He served as a priest and as a prophet. Through this work, he represented God to the people and brought the people's concerns before God.

Ezekiel 1:4

I ... saw a whirlwind: This language describes a theophany (a visible manifestation of God; see study note on Ezekiel 1:4–28) as God appears in judgment. The fiery presence coming from the north, the direction from which Israel's enemies traditionally came, increases the sense of danger. God was coming as a mighty warrior, not to rescue his people, but to bring judgment against them.

Ezekiel 1:4–28

The language of this opening vision describes a theophany (a visible appearance of God; see study note on Deuteronomy 1:33). Ezekiel found it hard to describe what he saw. He often used phrases such as "the appearance of," "looked like," and "the likeness of." These words show that the vision was beyond normal human experience.

Even so, the message is clear and serious. The vision combines movement with symbols of judgment. It warns that God's judgment would surely come upon rebellious Jerusalem.

Ezekiel 1:5–9

At the center of the fiery cloud were four living beings. Each one had four faces and four wings.

The number four often represents completeness in the Bible. These creatures, made up of different features, represented the whole created order (everything that God has made).

Ezekiel 1:10

Each living being had four faces. One face was a lion, the strongest of the wild animals. One face was an ox, the strongest of the domestic animals. One face was an eagle, the strongest of the birds. One face was human, representing the highest part of God's creation.

In Mesopotamia, the guardians placed at palace entrances also combined features of these same creatures. However, those figures did not have four faces.

Ezekiel 1:11–14

These fiery creatures had wings and legs. They could move very quickly in any direction, like lightning. No one could escape from such powerful beings.

In a similar vision in Ezekiel 10, Ezekiel identifies them as cherubim. Cherubim are heavenly beings who carry out God's judgment.

Ezekiel 1:15

The living creatures were not the only reason for fear. Among them, Ezekiel saw four wheels. These wheels were part of a divine war chariot (a chariot that symbolized God's power in battle).

In the ancient world, chariots were powerful weapons of war. Many people feared them because they moved quickly and caused great destruction.

Ezekiel 1:16–17

Building a real chariot with each wheel having another wheel turning sideways inside it is impossible. This image shows a chariot that can move easily in any direction, symbolizing God's freedom to act in judgment.

Ezekiel 1:18

The wheels were tall and frightening. They were covered with eyes (see Ezekiel 10:12). Because of this, no one could hide from the chariot. Just as no one could escape from it, no one could escape its sight.

Ezekiel 1:19–21

The chariot shared the same spirit as the living beings. The same life and power guided both the creatures and the wheels.

Ezekiel 1:22–25

The surface that looked like the sky, shining like crystal, separated God's realm from the human realm. It marked the boundary between heaven (the place of God's presence) and earth.

The vision includes images of the sky, the cherubim (see study note on Ezekiel 1:11–14), and the rainbow (Ezekiel 1:28). These images remind us of the opening chapters of Genesis. They suggest that the story about to unfold concerns the destruction of what God had created, followed by its re-creation (making it new again).

In Genesis, God destroyed the world with a flood and later restored it through Noah. In a similar way, Ezekiel's world was being undone and would later be restored.

Ezekiel 1:26–27

On God's throne was a figure that looked like a man. Ezekiel struggled to describe the scene because it was so magnificent. This human form showed the Lord's bright glory, which had once filled the tabernacle and the temple as a visible sign of God's presence (see Daniel 7:9–10; Revelation 1:12–17). God's presence in human form comforts his faithful people but warns of judgment for those who disobey him. This vision foretells God coming to earth as a man in Jesus Christ.

Ezekiel 1:28

- rainbow in a cloud: This image mixes the idea of judgment with a hint of mercy. The storm clouds were ready to bring judgment on God's sinful people, but a rainbow, the sign of hope God established after the flood (Genesis 9:12–17), would also appear.

Although the destruction of Jerusalem and the exile of its people to Babylon would be a severe disaster where many would die, God would remember his promise to keep a remnant alive. Judgment would not be God's final word.

- When Ezekiel saw the glory of the Lord, he fell face down on the ground as though dead. This was a common human response when people experienced God's glory (compare Leviticus 9:23–24; Numbers 22:31; 1 Kings 18:38–39; 1 Chronicles 21:16; 2 Chronicles 7:1–3; Matthew 17:5–6).

Ezekiel 2:1–2

stand up: God gave Ezekiel strength through the Spirit so that he could obey this command. God raised him to his feet.

Later, God would do something similar for the people as a whole (compare Ezekiel 37:4–10). What God later did for the nation, he first did for the prophet.

Ezekiel 2:1–10

Being a prophet was not a career that someone chose. It was also not a role passed down from father to son, as the priesthood was.

God himself called prophets to their task. Because of this, many prophets included the story of their call in their writings (see, for example, Isaiah 6; Jeremiah 1:4–19; Jonah 1:1–2).

Ezekiel 2:3

The Lord often addressed Ezekiel as son of man. In Hebrew, this phrase is ben-'adam, which means "son of Adam." It can also mean "human being."

This title reminded Ezekiel that he was human. He stood before heavenly beings, but he was different from them. He was a mortal person, created from the dust of the earth

The title also set Ezekiel apart from the people of Israel. The Bible often calls them "sons of Israel." They were descendants of Jacob, whose name was changed to Israel (Genesis 32:28). The name Israel means "he struggles with God."

At that time, Israel was a rebellious nation. By calling Ezekiel son of man, the Lord showed that Ezekiel did not stand with their rebellion. Instead, he stood as a faithful human servant before God.

As a son of Adam, Ezekiel represented a new beginning. God empowered him by the Spirit (the Holy Spirit, God's Spirit) to live in careful obedience. His life showed that it was possible to respond to God with faithfulness.

In this way, Ezekiel became a sign of hope to the exiles. Even in judgment, God was preparing a faithful people.

Jesus later used the title son of man for himself. This title points both to his humanity and to his heavenly authority. In Daniel 7:13–14, a figure "like a son of man" receives authority and an eternal kingdom from God. In Revelation 1:13–20), this title is used for the risen and exalted Christ. Jesus brings together the human meaning of the title and its heavenly meaning.

By obeying where Adam failed, Jesus became the first member of God's new community of faith. All other children of Adam find hope in him.

Ezekiel 2:4–5

Israel was stubborn and hard-hearted (unwilling to listen and obey). They would not listen to Ezekiel. His message would not show results right away. However, they would later know that a prophet had been among them speaking God's word.

Ezekiel 2:6

Ezekiel's ministry would be as difficult as walking through a patch of briers and thorns and stinging scorpions.

Ezekiel 2:7

Ezekiel was responsible only for delivering God's message faithfully, not for how people responded to it.

Ezekiel 2:8

Ezekiel should not be like the disobedient and rebellious people around him. The first man, Adam, disobeyed God's command not to eat the fruit of knowledge, which seemed desirable (Genesis 2:17). Ezekiel was to obey by eating God's words, which seemed undesirable.

Ezekiel 2:9–3.1

The scroll contained so many words of judgment that writing covered both sides. This showed how serious the message was.

Ezekiel had to announce the curses for breaking the covenant (God's promises and commands) to a rebellious people (see Deuteronomy 28:15–68; compare Zechariah 5:2–4).

This scroll full of judgment is a clear picture of the message in Ezekiel 1–24.

Ezekiel 3:2–3

Even though the scroll seemed bitter, Ezekiel found it as sweet as honey when he ate it. Adam's disobedience turned bitter, but Ezekiel's obedience became pleasant and satisfying. Psalm 119:103 also describes God's words as "sweet as honey."

Ezekiel 3:4–7

Ezekiel was sent to the people of Israel, who were expected to eagerly listen to the Lord. However, it would have been easier for the prophet if he had been sent to people with a strange and difficult language who could not understand him. This stubborn community refused to obey the Lord.

Ezekiel 3:8–9

God would make Ezekiel as persistent in delivering his message as the people were in rejecting it.

Ezekiel 3:10

Ezekiel needed to understand God's messages himself before sharing them with the exiles he lived among.

Ezekiel 3:11

whether they listen or refuse to listen: The Lord's message was final. It was not open to debate, negotiation, or rejection. Things would happen as he said.

Ezekiel 3:12

Blessed be the glory of the LORD in His dwelling place!: In the Hebrew text, this sentence is difficult. It appears in an unexpected place, and its grammar is unusual. Because of this, translators are not certain how best to understand it.

The Berean Standard Bible includes an alternate reading in a footnote: "sound behind me as the glory of the LORD rose from its place!" This alternate reading comes from changing one Hebrew letter. A small change like this is called an emendation (a suggested correction to the copied text).

If this alternate reading is followed, the sentence describes a loud sound as the glory of the Lord rises or moves. If the traditional wording is followed, the sentence is a statement of praise. Both readings are based on the Hebrew text, but they understand one letter differently.

Ezekiel 3:14–15

- So the Spirit lifted me up: Ezekiel was brought back from his visionary experience to the ordinary world of the exiles. Ezekiel regularly experienced the powerful impact of the Spirit's transporting him to another location (see also Ezekiel 8:3; 11:1, 24; 40:1–3; 43:5).
- After the Spirit left him, Ezekiel felt strong and mixed emotions about his calling. He did not feel calm or peaceful.

As a prophet who spoke for God, he began to feel bitterness and inner trouble. He shared in God's anger against the sins of his people.

Ezekiel 3:15

- The exact location of Tel-abib in Babylonia is unknown.
- As one of the exiles, Ezekiel felt overwhelmed by the idea of this terrible judgment. Like Job's counselors, he could not speak at first and sat silently for seven days (see Job 2:13).

Ezekiel 3:16–19

Ezekiel was called to be a watchman, a common role for Old Testament prophets (see Isaiah 56:10; Jeremiah 6:17; Hosea 9:8). The watchman looked out for the community. He had to warn people about approaching enemies so they could find safety in time. In this case, the enemy was not a human invader but God. If Ezekiel stayed silent, he would be responsible for the blood of those he failed to warn.

Ezekiel 3:20–21

The prophet spoke to two groups of people: the righteous and the wicked. Ezekiel had to deliver his message to both groups. He did not choose who would hear it.

Both the righteous and the wicked would be judged by how they responded to his word (see Matthew 13:3–9, 18–23). Those who listened and obeyed would receive life. Those who rejected his message would receive death, even if they had once been righteous.

Faith in the Lord's word, spoken through his prophet, was the only standard that separated those who would live from those who would die.

Ezekiel 3:22–23

- The Lord called Ezekiel to go out into the valley. This was a lonely place, away from other people.
- This was the second time Ezekiel had seen the glory of the Lord. Even so, he had not become used to it. The greatness and holiness of God's glory overwhelmed him, and he fell face down on the ground.

Ezekiel 3:24–25

Ezekiel was like a prisoner of God. He was shut inside his house and tied with ropes.

It is not clear whether these ropes were real. Some think the other exiles tied him because they were hostile toward him. Others think this is a strong picture that shows their opposition and how his movements were restricted among them.

His captivity was complete. God also limited his speech (Ezekiel 3:26–27). This unusual situation was meant to be a sign to the people.

Ezekiel 3:26–27

God also controlled Ezekiel's speech. It was as if his tongue were bound to the roof of his mouth. He could speak only when God allowed him to speak words of judgment.

Ezekiel was not physically unable to talk. However, God limited what he could say. He could announce only the message of disaster that God gave him. He was not allowed to speak anything else.

This made Ezekiel's role different from that of most prophets. Many prophets could pray for the people and speak to God on their behalf. Ezekiel could not do this because the time for dialogue between God and his people had ended. No further appeal could stop the coming judgment.

His speech would remain restricted until news arrived that Jerusalem had fallen (Ezekiel 24:27). After God's judgment was complete, Ezekiel's tongue would be freed. Then he would again be able to speak for the people.

Ezekiel 4:1–2

The first of Ezekiel's sign acts was a visual message. A sign act is a symbolic action that teaches a lesson (see "Prophetic Sign Acts" Theme Note).

God told Ezekiel to build a small model of Jerusalem. He then showed the city surrounded by enemy forces. This model picture showed that Jerusalem would soon be under siege (surrounded and attacked by an army).

Ezekiel 4:1–7.27

These chapters discuss words and actions that warned of disaster for Jerusalem (Ezekiel 4–5) and the land of Judah (Ezekiel 6–7).

Ezekiel 4:1–24.27

The prophet Ezekiel used words and actions to show that judgment on Jerusalem was certain. God's people broke the covenant made at Mount Sinai. Now, they faced the promised curses of death and destruction. Only after these curses happened could there be hope for the future.

Ezekiel 4:3

The prophet was to take on the role of God in this dramatic scene. The iron griddle set up between him and the city showed that Jerusalem had separated itself from God.

Meanwhile, the prophet was to face the city with determination, showing that God was still focused and firmly resolved to destroy Jerusalem in the upcoming siege.

Ezekiel 4:4–5

Israel refers to the entire covenant community, not just the northern kingdom. The number 390 has been interpreted in different ways. A likely explanation is that 390 represents years. It may refer to the time from early in Solomon's reign, which lasted from 971 to 931 BC, to the destruction of Jerusalem in 586 BC (see 2 Kings 25:3–7).

Ezekiel 4:4–8

The prophet's second sign act was connected to the first. This time, he acted out the roles of both God and the people suffering during the siege.

As someone suffering in the siege, he was tied with ropes (Ezekiel 4:8). He had to lie in one position. He may not have stayed like this all the time during the 14 months. Instead, he may have performed this sign each day.

When Ezekiel represented Israel, he symbolically bore Israel's sins. This means he acted out the weight of their guilt by lying on one side. However, he did not bring atonement (the removal of sin) or forgiveness to Israel.

Ezekiel 4:6

- Judah refers to the community of people living in exile. Their time away from the land is pictured as 40 years. This number suggests that they were like a lost generation. It recalls the generation that wandered 40 years in the wilderness because of their sin (Numbers 14:34).
- The 430 days of Ezekiel's confinement (Ezekiel 4:5) match the 430 years that Israel lived in Egypt (Exo-

dus 12:40). This parallel suggests hope. Just as God once led his people out of Egypt, he would bring them out of exile. It points to the promise of a new exodus at the end of the exile.

Ezekiel 4:7

Ezekiel continued to represent God in this acted message. He showed what God was doing and saying.

With his arm bared (uncovered as a sign of strength and readiness to act), he looked steadily at the city under attack. He fixed his eyes on the siege of Jerusalem. As he did this, he announced that the city would be destroyed.

Ezekiel 4:9–17

The near-starvation diet of eight ounces of food and a jar of water each day represents siege rations. This reflects a desperate situation where there was not enough of any one type of grain to make a whole loaf.

Ezekiel 4:12–13

Cooking with human excrement (human waste) would make the bread ceremonially unclean. This means it would be unfit for worship according to the law of Moses. If Ezekiel ate it, he would become unclean.

This act was a sign of what would happen to the Israelites in exile. In a foreign land, it would be very hard to follow the kosher dietary laws (the food laws God gave to Israel). As a result, they would eat food that was unclean.

Because of this, they would be unclean and separated from the Lord's cleansing presence (his holy presence that makes people pure).

Ezekiel 4:14–15

The prophet said he had never eaten anything unclean. The Lord agreed, letting Ezekiel cook his food over cow dung. He also followed the law for disposing of human waste (see Deuteronomy 23:12–14).

Ezekiel 5:1–4

The prophet had to perform two more sign acts (symbolic actions that showed God's message).

First, he took a sharp sword and used it like a razor. He shaved his head and his beard. This action showed the coming destruction described in Ezekiel 4 (compare Isaiah 7:20). In that culture, shaving off a man's hair showed the loss of honor and strength. It was a public sign of shame (see 2 Samuel 10:4–5).

Second, Ezekiel weighed the hair he had shaved. He divided it into three equal parts. This action showed that God's judgment would come in three different ways. It also showed that God's judgment was measured and purposeful.

Ezekiel 5:2

Ezekiel was to burn one-third of the hair to show those who would die from hunger during the siege. He was to cut another third with a sword to show those who would die violently. He was to scatter the last third to the wind to show those who would go into exile.

Ezekiel 5:3–4

Ezekiel was to tie a small amount of hair in his robe to show that a few people would be safe. However, even some of them would die during the exile. Only a few would survive the many disasters about to happen to God's people.

Ezekiel 5:5–6

The reason for God's judgment on his people is very clear. Israel had broken its covenant (the binding promise relationship) with God.

Because of this broken covenant, God brought judgment on them.

Ezekiel 5:7–13

The covenant (the binding promise relationship) between God and his people forms the foundation of Ezekiel's messages.

When Ezekiel listed the charges against the Israelites, he used the same language as the covenant made at Mount Sinai. That covenant was later renewed in the book of Deuteronomy.

The people refused to obey God's decrees and regulations (his laws and commands). They also worshiped detestable idols (false gods that God hates). These idols defiled the temple of the Lord, which was meant to be holy. By doing this, they broke God's covenant requirements (see Leviticus 26:1–2, 14–15).

Because they disobeyed the Lord, the covenant curses (the promised punishments for disobedience) would now take effect (see Leviticus 26:16–43; Deuteronomy 28:15–68).

Ezekiel 5:10

fathers among you will eat their sons: This terrible event would happen during a time of severe famine (a time when there is no food). When people become

desperate and have nothing to eat, such suffering can occur (see 2 Kings 6:26–30).

This was also one of the covenant curses (the promised punishments for disobedience). God had warned that this would happen if the people rejected him (see Leviticus 26:29).

Ezekiel 6:1–3

The judgment did not remain only in Jerusalem. It spread to the mountains of Israel, which were the political center of the nation.

This land had belonged to Israel since the time of Joshua. Over time, however, it became filled with idolatry (the worship of false gods).

The hill country became the location of many pagan shrines, called high places (raised stone platforms used for worship). These places often held idols or were used for sacrifices and pagan celebrations. Many of these shrines were already there before Israel entered the land.

God had commanded the people to destroy them (Deuteronomy 12:2–3). Instead, in many places, the Israelites allowed them to remain. Some political and religious leaders ignored the problem. Others even encouraged the people who worshiped at these sites.

Ezekiel 6:1–14

This chapter contains two messages of judgment (Ezekiel 6:2–10 and 6:11–14). These messages give two possible outcomes.

The first outcome is hope. If the people repent (turn away from sin and return to God), they will have a future.

The second outcome is continued rebellion. If they refuse to change, they will face complete destruction.

In either case, the Lord's power and holiness will be clearly shown.

Ezekiel 6:4–7

- The corpses and bones of dead worshipers around an altar would make the altar ceremonially unclean and unfit for use.
- idols: The Hebrew word translated idols literally means "round things." It may also sound like a word for dung (human or animal waste). When the prophets used this word, they were mocking the idols. It was a strong expression of disgust and rejection.

Ezekiel 6:8–10

A remnant (a small group that remains) would be scattered among the nations. God would send them into many lands. There, they would bear witness to God's faithfulness to his covenant (his promises to his people).

In those foreign lands, they would see the truth about their own hearts. They would understand how they had been unfaithful to God. They would hate their evil and detestable sins. Then they would know that God was serious when he warned that he would punish those who broke his covenant.

Some of those who came to know that the Lord alone is God might also see another side of his faithfulness. They might experience his readiness to forgive those who truly repent (turn away from sin).

In the book of Exodus, Israel came to know that the Lord is God through his mighty acts of rescue (see Exodus 6:7). He saved them from slavery in Egypt. But later, their actions showed that they had forgotten him. Now they would come to know him again, not only through rescue, but also through judgment.

Ezekiel 6:11

Ezekiel's message did not end with the hopeful idea that some people might repent (turn back to God).

He returned to the theme of judgment. He warned about three coming disasters. These were war, famine (a time with no food), and disease.

Ezekiel 6:12

he who remains: See Ezekiel 5:3–4.

Ezekiel 6:13–14

Riblah was on Israel's northern border and is mentioned in other biblical books. At Riblah, Nebuchadnezzar held his court and executed Zedekiah's sons and many important citizens of Judah (2 Kings 25:6, 21).

Ezekiel 7:1–2

As the prophet shared his message, the scope of the threatened judgment grew, like ripples from a stone in a pond. Now, the judgment was not just for Israel, as in Ezekiel 6, but for the entire land, east, west, north, and south. This global judgment on God's people would be like the end of the world. Judgment was no longer near, as in earlier messages. It had arrived.

Ezekiel 7:1–27

Ezekiel 7 contains three messages of doom (7:3–4, 5–9, 10–27). These messages reminded Judah that their coming destruction was not random. It was an act of the Lord's judgment.

Ezekiel 7:3–4

- There was no hope that God would change his mind.
- Then you will know that I am the LORD: When they received what they deserved, the people would recognize the Lord's power and holiness.

Ezekiel 7:5–9

A second message repeats that the coming judgment would be personal. The people would not only know that God is the Lord, as in Ezekiel 7:4. They would feel his judgment in their own lives.

The Lord, who once revealed himself to his people as "the LORD who heals you" (Exodus 15:26), had now become "the LORD, who strikes the blow." The day of the Lord had arrived. This is a time when God steps in to judge and act in power (Joel 1:15; Amos 5:18–20).

Ezekiel 7:10

rod has budded: The evil and pride of the people of Israel had fully grown. Their sin had reached its peak. They were ready for judgment, like fruit that is ripe and ready to be picked (see Amos 8:1–2).

Ezekiel 7:11

Their violence has grown into a rod to punish their wickedness: The people's violent actions had grown strong. Now that violence would turn against them. God would use their own sin to punish them. He would allow fighting and conflict to rise up among them (see Proverbs 6:27).

Their wealth and prestige (honor and high position) could not save them. When destruction came like a powerful flood, these things would not protect them.

Ezekiel 7:12–13

Commercial transactions would lose their meaning. Buying and selling would no longer matter.

There would be no such thing as a good deal or a bad deal. Buyers and sellers alike would face God's terrible anger.

Ezekiel 7:12–27

Comprehensive judgment is shown in two matching sections: Ezekiel 7:12–18 and 7:19–27.

Each section begins by showing that material gain (money and property) is useless in light of the coming judgment. Then the text describes the arrival of war and its terrible results. Finally, each section ends with a picture of fear, helplessness, and deep mourning among the people.

Ezekiel 7:14

When Israel sounded the trumpet in holy war (a battle fought in the name of the Lord), something different would happen.

In the past, the troops would gather quickly. The enemy would become afraid and confused (see Numbers 10:9; Joshua 6:4–20; Judges 6:34; 7:16–22; Nehemiah 4:18–20).

But now, when the trumpet sounded, the soldiers would not rally. The enemy would not be terrified. The old victories would not be repeated.

Ezekiel 7:19

Even silver and gold, which people usually trust in times of crisis, would not save them. These treasures would not protect their owners. They would not even satisfy their hunger.

The people would throw their silver and gold away. They would treat these riches like worthless trash (something unclean, hateful, and disgusting). They would want to get rid of them as quickly as possible.

Ezekiel 7:20–22

- Their once valuable objects became contaminated because they were used to make offensive idols and images.
- God would give his treasured land, the home of his sanctuary (Deuteronomy 12:5, 11), to harsh and ruthless pagans. Israel repeatedly failed to distinguish between true and false worship places, continued pagan worship at high places, and even brought idols into the temple (Ezekiel 8). Therefore, God would destroy the pagan worship centers in the land and even in the temple in Jerusalem.

In the past, God defended Jerusalem against overwhelming odds (see 2 Kings 18:1–19:37), but now he would leave her to her deserved fate.

Ezekiel 7:23–27

Religious leaders (prophets and priests) and civil leaders (kings or princes) could not bring the peace the people wanted. Both the rich and the poor would be powerless when facing judgment. Without guidance or direction, the people would have no hope.

Ezekiel 8:1

We are now in the sixth year of King Jehoiachin's captivity (see study note on Ezekiel 1:2). Fourteen months have passed since Ezekiel first saw his opening vision.

During most of that time, the prophet had been acting out the sign acts described in Ezekiel 4. These were symbolic actions that showed what would happen to Jerusalem.

Ezekiel 8–9 describes, in visions, the same defilement (moral and spiritual uncleanness) and judgment of Jerusalem that Ezekiel 7 announces in spoken messages. In these visions, God shows Ezekiel the sins of the city and the punishment that would follow.

This time, Ezekiel spoke to the leaders of Judah (literally elders). They had gathered at his house. They were likely hoping to hear a message of encouragement and comfort from the Lord (see also Ezekiel 14:1; 20:1). Instead, they heard a strong rebuke for the sins of the communities they represented.

Ezekiel 8:1–18

In a vision, the prophet Ezekiel saw four ways the people defiled their land. This vision explains why the Lord's presence left his sanctuary.

Ezekiel 8:1–11.25

This section describes how the people defiled (made unclean by sin) the temple in Jerusalem (Ezekiel 8). Because of this sin, the Lord left the temple. After he left, the city and the temple were destroyed (9:1–11:13).

At first, this sounds like only bad news. But for those already living in exile, it was also good news. The Lord was not limited to the temple in Jerusalem. He would come to be with his people in exile.

By coming to dwell with them, the Lord showed that the exiles were not forgotten. They were the ones who carried hope for the future of God's people.

Ezekiel 8:2–3

- While the leaders gathered, Ezekiel saw a vision of what seemed to be a man. The description is similar to the one in Ezekiel 1:26–27. This time, Ezekiel was lifted into the sky and transported to Jerusalem.
- like that of ... His appearance was like ... looked like: What Ezekiel saw went beyond normal human experience (see study note on Ezekiel 1:4–28).

Ezekiel 8:3–6

In the first abomination, the large idol was probably an image of the Canaanite goddess Asherah. The people had placed it at the gate to guard the city from attack.

Most of Jerusalem's enemies had attacked from the north. This may explain why the idol stood at the north gate. The people believed this false goddess would protect them.

This idol made the Lord very jealous. The Lord alone deserved honor and worship as Israel's protector (Psalm 121:1–4). The Lord was offended because the people trusted an idol to guard the city he had chosen.

Ezekiel 8:3–16

God showed Ezekiel four scenes of increasing abomination (a deeply offensive act). In each scene, the people of Israel were worshiping false gods inside the Lord's temple.

Jerusalem's defilement (moral and spiritual uncleanness) was complete. Idolatry (the worship of false gods) took place in many parts of the temple. Different groups of people were involved. They worshiped different gods. These gods came from many foreign cultures.

This was not one small sin. It was a mixture of many false religions brought together in one place. One abomination was added to another.

Ezekiel 8:7–8

The first abomination was public, while the second was private. To see it in his vision, the prophet had to dig into the wall to find a hidden doorway.

Ezekiel 8:10

The practice of worshiping gods shaped like crawling animals and other detestable creatures likely came from Egypt.

In Egypt, people often worshiped gods that were shown in the form of animals. By copying these practices, the people of Israel brought foreign worship into the Lord's temple.

Ezekiel 8:11

- These 70 leaders are very different from the 70 leaders from the time of Moses. Those leaders had the special privilege of seeing God (Exodus 24:1–11). They also received the same Spirit that was on Moses (Numbers 11:16–30).

Jaazaniah led this group. Ironically, he was the son of Shaphan. Shaphan had been a faithful leader who helped carry out King Josiah's reforms (2 Kings 22:3–14).

- The incense they burned was meant to protect them from demonic spirits (evil spiritual beings). Instead of protecting them, it brought God's judgment on the land.

Ezekiel 8:12–13

The Lord saw the actions of Israel's leaders and shared this with his prophet (compare Luke 12:3).

Ezekiel 8:14–15

The third abomination was that women were weeping for the god Tammuz at the north gate of the Lord's temple.

Tammuz was a Babylonian god. He was also called Dumuzi. This ritual marked his death and descent into the underworld (the place of the dead). Each year, people believed that this god lost his power and later regained it. They connected this cycle to the yearly changes in nature, such as the dying and growing of crops.

The women mourned for Tammuz in a ritual ceremony. They believed that their mourning would help bring back fertility (the ability to produce crops and life) to the land.

Instead of praising and worshiping the true and living God, the people were grieving for a false god who was said to die each year.

Ezekiel 8:16

- The fourth and final act of idolatry took place in the very center of the temple complex. It happened in the inner courtyard of the temple of the Lord. This was as close as a person could come to the temple building without entering it.
- The 25 men worshiping the sun were likely priests, since only priests should have accessed this area. It is also possible that they were not priests and were openly breaking the rules.

These men stood physically closer to the Lord's presence than anyone else. Yet they had turned their backs toward the sanctuary. Instead of worshiping their Creator, they worshiped something he had created (see Romans 1:25).

Ezekiel 8:17–18

The abominations that the Israelites were committing in the temple complex were like openly insulting the Lord.

The Hebrew expression literally says they were "putting the twig [or branch] to their nose." This was likely a rude gesture. It showed defiance and disrespect.

In other words, their actions were not only sinful. They were boldly rebellious against the Lord.

Ezekiel 9:1–2

The prophet did not have to wait long for judgment to come.

The Lord called his angelic warriors (heavenly messengers who carry out God's commands) to punish the city. In response, seven men appeared.

Six of the men carried deadly weapons. The seventh man was dressed in linen (the clothing often worn by priests). He carried a writer's case, a small box used to hold writing tools.

They stood ready in the temple courtyard. They were beside the bronze altar, where sacrifices were usually offered.

Ezekiel 9:3

The glory of the God of Israel, which is the visible sign of his presence, started to leave the defiled temple. It first rose from between the cherubim, above the ark in the Most Holy Place, where it usually rested. Then, it moved to the temple entrance, preparing to leave its former throne.

Ezekiel 9:4–6

The man dressed in linen (Ezekiel 9:2–3) marked those to be kept safe, similar to the first Passover (Exodus 12:7–13). Meanwhile, the angels of destruction carried out a complete judgment (Exodus 12:28–30). This time, they targeted everyone without the protective mark, including old and young, girls, women, and children. Unlike in Egypt, where only the firstborn males were affected, all who did not mourn over the city's sins were destroyed (compare Revelation 7:1–8).

Ezekiel 9:7

Defile the temple: In the past, Queen Athaliah was dragged out of the temple before she was executed. This was done so that her blood would not defile (make unclean) the holy place (2 Kings 11:15–16).

Now the situation was different. These idolaters were to be killed inside the temple. Their idolatry had already defiled it so deeply that nothing sacred remained there.

Without God's holy presence, the building was no longer truly holy. Protecting its outer purity would have been an empty act

Ezekiel 9:8

Ezekiel feared he might be the only person left after the Lord showed his anger.

Ezekiel 9:9–10

The Lord replied that he would fully repay Israel's sins (see Ezekiel 9:3–4, 11).

Ezekiel 9:11

I have done as You commanded: The remnant had been successfully marked to save them from the wrath to come (Ezekiel 9:3–4).

Ezekiel 10:1–2

- This vision of God's fearful and holy glory was almost the same as the one Ezekiel had seen earlier in Babylonia (Ezekiel 1). Now he saw it again, but this time in the temple in Jerusalem.

The temple was filled with symbols of heaven. In this vision, Ezekiel understood clearly that the living creatures he had seen before were cherubim. Cherubim are powerful heavenly beings who guard God's holiness and carry out his judgment (Genesis 3:24).

- A priestly figure was told to gather burning coals from among the cherubim. This action showed that Jerusalem, which had become unclean because of sin, would be destroyed by fire. This judgment was like what happened to the city of Sodom (see Ezekiel 16:46–50).

The vision also showed that the Lord was leaving his city. Later, this became a reality in history. A few years after this vision, King Nebuchadnezzar burned Jerusalem and filled the city with dead bodies.

Ezekiel 10:1–22

The temple was the earthly place where the Lord's glory dwelled among his people. This was one of the greatest blessings of the covenant.

But this blessing depended on the people being holy (set apart for God and living in obedience to him). When they filled the temple with sin and idolatry, they defiled it.

Because of their unfaithfulness, the Lord left his house. Once his presence departed, the temple and the city were left unprotected. They became vulnerable to the coming attack by the Babylonians.

Ezekiel 10:3–22

The glory of the Lord did not leave the temple all at once. It moved slowly, step by step, almost as if it was unwilling to depart (Ezekiel 10:4).

First, the glory of the Lord moved from above the cherubim in the Most Holy Place. Then it went to the entrance of the temple and stopped there for a time. After that, it rose above the cherubim again (Ezekiel 10:18) and moved to the east gate of the courtyard, where it paused once more (10:19). Eventually, the glory of the Lord left the city completely (11:23).

Ezekiel 10:12

full of eyes: The elders' earlier statement that "The LORD does not see us" (Ezekiel 8:12) was both foolish and false.

Ezekiel 10:19–22

From this point on, the city was doomed.

God had shown his powerful and fearsome glory in the opening chapter of Ezekiel. Now that same God had left the city.

Without his presence, Jerusalem no longer had protection or hope. Judgment would surely come.

Ezekiel 11:1–11

The Spirit showed Ezekiel God's view of Jerusalem, then let him hear the city's people. The wicked advisors claimed that although the Babylonian attack (the fire) was difficult (hot), the city's defenses (the pot) were strong enough to protect them (the meat). These advisors encouraged people to build houses on stolen land (see Ezekiel 11:15, 17), believing they would be safe. God, however, was determined to judge the wicked.

Ezekiel 11:8–10

God once saved his people from foreigners in Egypt, but now he would give them over to foreigners for judgment.

Ezekiel 11:13

- The judgment that the Lord announced happened at once.

- Oh, Lord GOD, will You bring the remnant of Israel to a complete end?: If those who still remained in the land were going to be completely destroyed, then who would be left? Who would continue as God's people?

Ezekiel 11:15–16

- Those who stayed in the land thought the exiles were far from the Lord, with no one to protect their family land. Normally, relatives (literally men of your redemption) would have redeemed Ezekiel's family property if he faced debt or trouble. Since the exiles left as family groups, no one remained in Judah to guard their inherited properties.
- this land has been given to us as a possession: Those who stayed thought the exiles were under God's judgment and had lost their ancestral lands. The opposite was true. Israel's future was with the distant exiles, as the Lord went with them and would be a sanctuary during their exile (see Ezekiel 11:22–23).

Ezekiel 11:17

The exile in Babylon would last until God completed his judgment. Afterward, God's people would return from the nations where they had been scattered to the land of Israel. Their land, currently taken by those remaining in Judah, would be restored to them.

Ezekiel 11:19

The outward change in the lives of God's people would match an inward change. God would not only restore their situation. He would also change their hearts. The heart includes a person's thoughts, desires, decisions, and will.

They would have singleness of heart. This means they would have complete loyalty to the Lord. In the past, their hearts had wandered away from him.

God would give them a tender and responsive heart (literally a heart of flesh). This would replace their hard and stubborn heart (literally their heart of stone).

Instead of their old spirit that led them to worship idols, God would give them a new spirit (see Ezekiel 36:26–27).

Ezekiel 11:20

Their transformed hearts and spirits would allow the Lord's people to follow his rules. This would achieve the covenant's goal: people living with God among them. The new heart and spirit promised to God's people have become real (Hebrews 8:8–13). Through the Spirit's outpouring at Pentecost, God's people have become a new creation (2 Corinthians 5:17).

Ezekiel 11:21

Those who stayed in the land would face the consequences of their actions. God would fully repay them for their sins, especially those involving offensive images and idols.

Ezekiel 11:22–23

Ezekiel's vision of the temple (Ezekiel 8–11) ends with the chariot carrying God's glory away from the temple. The Lord's glory would leave the defiled Jerusalem, travel east to Babylon with the exiles, and share in their suffering (Ezekiel 11:16).

God's glory paused briefly above the Mount of Olives, east of Jerusalem, as if waiting for judgment to fall on the rebellious city. After departing to the east, it would return from the east to the renewed temple (Ezekiel 43).

Ezekiel 12:1–2

The people of Judah were not the only ones with stubborn hearts who resisted the prophet's message (Ezekiel 11:19). The exiles living with Ezekiel were also rebellious. They refused to see their wrongdoings and ignored his message, just like those who remained in Judah.

Ezekiel 12:1–24.27

This section brings together different prophecies and sign acts. A sign act is a symbolic action that a prophet performs to show God's message.

These prophecies and actions all share one main message. They announce God's judgment against Jerusalem and its leaders because of their sin.

Ezekiel 12:5–7

Ezekiel was to dig a hole through the wall to sneak out of a besieged city without being noticed, similar to what Zedekiah later tried to do (2 Kings 25:4).

Ezekiel 12:12–13

King Zedekiah could not foresee the coming judgment. He would not see the land he was leaving or the land of the Babylonians. This prophecy came true when the Babylonians captured Zedekiah as he fled from besieged Jerusalem. They forced him to watch as they tortured his sons to death, then they blinded him (2 Kings 25:1–7).

This terrible end for Judah's last king did not happen only because Babylon wanted to expand its empire. More importantly, the Lord himself planned to judge the king.

Ezekiel 12:16

The few unhappy survivors confessed their terrible sins to their captors. They did not do this out of repentance, but because they recognized that the Lord had judged them fairly.

Ezekiel 12:17–20

Ezekiel trembled and shook while he ate and drank. This was a sign act, a symbolic action that showed God's message.

His shaking showed the fear and anxiety of the people living in Jerusalem and Judah. They would see that destruction was coming and that they could not escape it.

Later, the exiles would hear that their homeland had been destroyed. Then they would understand something important. They were not rejected by God. Instead, they were the ones who had escaped his complete judgment (see Jeremiah 24:1–8).

Ezekiel 12:21–14.11

The messages in this section address the issue of true and false prophecy.

Ezekiel 12:22

Ezekiel's hearers did not want to listen to the message of the prophets. They were unwilling to accept what God was saying.

Because of this, they created a proverb. A proverb is a short saying that expresses a common belief. This proverb showed their doubt and disbelief.

Ezekiel 12:23–25

The people did not believe the message from God (Ezekiel 12:22). So the Lord gave them a new proverb.

He used words that were similar to their saying. But he gave those words a different and opposite meaning.

Ezekiel 12:26–28

The people responded with a second proverb, and again the Lord refuted them. What the Lord had threatened, he would do.

Ezekiel 13:1–3

The basic difference between true and false prophets was clear. False prophets made up their own messages. True prophets spoke the word of the Lord.

Now the false prophets would hear a message from the Lord. This message was about their own destruction.

These messengers had been deceived, and they had also deceived others. Great sorrow and judgment were coming upon them.

Ezekiel 13:4–5

People compare false prophets to jackals that dig in ruins to hunt small animals. These false prophets did not fix the broken walls by urging people to repent, live holy lives, and resist evil. Instead, they gained prestige, and possibly money, by spreading lies that encouraged rebellion. Like jackals, these false prophets were tearing down walls, not building them up (see Nehemiah 4:3).

Ezekiel 13:6–7

The false prophets knew their words were lies and false predictions. Yet, they confidently expected God to fulfill their prophecies. These false hopes gave God's people a false sense of security. This false security would prove empty and destructive on the coming day of judgment (compare Jeremiah 6:14).

Ezekiel 13:8–9

The false prophets wanted to protect themselves. But this desire would bring the opposite result.

Instead of being safe, they would be removed from the community. They would never return to their own land again.

Ezekiel 13:10–16

The people's "righteousness" was like a weak wall ready to fall. Instead of urging the people to repent and build their wall properly, the false prophets just painted over it. They told the people that peace would come to Jerusalem.

This made the wall look stronger than it was. A heavy rainstorm would reveal its true weakness. Water would seep into the unsealed cracks, wash away the mortar, and cause the stones to fall.

In this case, the storm would be the great flood of God's anger, which would destroy the people's false righteousness and the false prophets who supported it. Meanwhile, they would find no peace.

Ezekiel 13:17–19

Similar to the false male prophets (Ezekiel 13:1–16), some women prophets spoke words from their own imaginations. The false male prophets used traditional prophecy methods, but the women used magical techniques with charms and veils. Seeking personal gain, such as a few handfuls of barley or a piece of bread, they promised life and death (compare Ezekiel 3:17–21; 33:1–9) to the wrong people.

Ezekiel 13:20–23

The false women prophets did not speak about life and death the way God did. They did not judge people by God's standards.

Because of this, they discouraged righteous people. The righteous began to think that obeying God was useless. At the same time, these false prophets encouraged wicked people. The wicked began to believe they could continue in sin and not be punished.

This wrong teaching trapped both groups. It gave the righteous and the wicked false ideas about who God is and how he judges.

Ezekiel 14:1–3

The leaders of the exiled community of Israel visited Ezekiel again, likely seeking encouragement (see Ezekiel 8:1; 20:1). The people were involved in similar sins, such as idolatry, that also affected those in Judah (see Ezekiel 8:10–12).

Ezekiel 14:4–5

The exiles acted as if they were seeking the Lord. But they were only going through the motions. They performed the outward actions, yet their hearts had turned away from him. They were worshiping idols, which the Lord calls detestable (deeply hateful and unclean).

It was easy for them to think that Babylon's many military victories proved something. They could begin to believe that real power belonged to the Babylonian gods, not to the Lord.

Ezekiel 14:6–7

When people rebel against God and then ask for his guidance, they should expect only one answer: Repent (turn back from wrongdoing and return to God).

Ezekiel 14:8

Rather than using a false prophet to give divine guidance, the Lord would respond directly with a severe act of judgment. This would remove them from among his people. Whether this means death or excommunication, these insincere leaders would be taken out of the covenant community, the only place where true life exists.

Ezekiel 14:9–10

False prophets tried to oppose God's will by predicting things God had not said. However, they unknowingly fulfilled God's will. They and other rebels were misled and remained in their rebellion. Both false prophets and rebellious people faced punishment for their sins (see also Deuteronomy 13; 1 Kings 22:6–23).

Ezekiel 14:11

The goal of God's judgment was not the total destruction of the exiles but their salvation, so that the people of Israel would learn not to remain faithful to the Lord.

Ezekiel 14:12–20

- Israel had not been treated unfairly. God did not judge Israel without reason. If any nation sinned against the Lord in this way, that nation would face the same result.

However, this passage clearly speaks about Israel. The words used to describe their sin also describe breaking the covenant (the binding promises between God and his people). Israel had broken this covenant. Because of that, the nation would rightly experience the covenant curses (the punishments promised for disobedience) listed in Leviticus 26. The people had agreed to these terms when the covenant was first made.

- The covenant curses appear here in four test cases. Each case shows one of the judgments listed in Leviticus 26:

1. Famine (a severe lack of food), as described in Ezekiel 14:13–14 and Leviticus 26:26.
2. Wild animals attacking the land, as described in Ezekiel 14:15–16 and Leviticus 26:22.
3. War, as described in Ezekiel 14:17–18 and Leviticus 26:25.
4. Disease, as described in Ezekiel 14:19–20 and Leviticus 26:25.

These examples show that Israel's suffering was not random. It was the direct result of breaking the covenant with the Lord.

Ezekiel 14:14

- Noah, Daniel, and Job: Each of these men was known for remaining faithful in a wicked generation. They lived among people who did evil, but they obeyed God.

If anyone could deserve a delay in God's judgment, it would be these men. However, even if a land included these three righteous men, their righteousness would not save their own sons or daughters from coming disaster (Ezekiel 14:20). Their obedience could only save themselves. It would certainly not save a rebellious nation.

- Some people question whether Ezekiel meant the prophet Daniel. In Ezekiel 14 and 28:3, the Hebrew spelling of the name Daniel (Dani'el) is slightly different from the spelling in the book of Daniel (Daniyye'l). Because of this difference, some scholars suggest that Ezekiel referred to a legendary pagan hero named Danel.

However, small differences in spelling are common in the Hebrew Old Testament. Ezekiel and his listeners would have known about the prophet Daniel, who lived in Babylon at the same time as Ezekiel. Daniel was already known as a model of righteousness and wisdom. It is unlikely that Ezekiel, who strongly opposed idolatry, would choose a pagan hero to represent perfect righteousness. For this reason, Ezekiel most likely meant the prophet Daniel.

Ezekiel 14:21

Jerusalem was worse than the imaginary land described in Ezekiel 14:12–20 in two ways.

First, Jerusalem did not have men like Noah, Daniel, and Job. Instead, the city was full of unrighteous people. There were no well-known righteous leaders whose faithfulness might stand out before God.

Second, Jerusalem would not suffer only one judgment. It would face all four terrible punishments at the same time. These included famine, wild animals, war, and disease, as described earlier in the chapter.

Because of this, it is not surprising that many people and animals in the city would die. The judgment would be complete and severe.

Ezekiel 14:22–23

Some survivors would emerge from the devastating judgment (Ezekiel 14:21) and join those already in exile. They would not survive because of their own righteousness or that of their relatives, but as an object lesson for those in exile. As the exiles saw the depravity of this remnant, they would feel better about what God had done to Jerusalem. The exiles would understand that God had acted with justice in his judgment upon Jerusalem, not without cause.

Ezekiel 15:1–5

The wood of most trees can be used to make many useful objects. Even small pieces can serve as pegs, which are simple wooden pins used to hang or hold things in place.

The wood of a vine is different. It is weak and thin. It is not strong enough to make pegs or other tools.

It is not even useful as firewood. It burns too quickly and does not give much heat. In this way, vine wood is completely useless.

Ezekiel 15:1–24.14

This section includes eight metaphors, each showing from a different angle the certainty of Jerusalem's upcoming judgment. The images are of:

1. a worthless vine (Ezekiel 15);
2. a faithless wife (Ezekiel 16);
3. a vine and two eagles (Ezekiel 17);
4. Sour grapes (Ezekiel 18);
5. a lion and her cubs (Ezekiel 19);
6. a sword (Ezekiel 21);
7. two corrupt sisters (Ezekiel 23); and
8. a cooking pot (Ezekiel 24).

Ezekiel 15:6

- The people of Jerusalem are like grapevines (compare Psalm 80:8–9; Isaiah 5:1–7; Jeremiah 2:21; John 15:1–6).
- Grapevines growing among forest trees do not bear fruit because they lack enough sunlight.

Ezekiel 15:7

Anyone who escaped one "fire" of God's judgment would not truly be safe. Here, "fire" is a picture of severe judgment.

This first fire likely refers to the defeat of Judah by King Nebuchadnezzar of Babylon in 597 BC (2 Kings 21:1–4). Some people survived that attack and were taken into exile.

But those who escaped that disaster would soon face another one. This second fire refers to the final destruction of Jerusalem in 586 BC. In other words, escaping the first judgment would not prevent the second.

Ezekiel 15:8

unfaithfully: See Ezekiel 6:9; 16:17; Hosea 2. Jerusalem had turned away from the Lord and followed idols instead of serving the true God. This was spiritual unfaithfulness. The prophets often describe this sin as breaking faith in a marriage relationship.

By worshiping idols, the people broke the covenant (the binding promises between God and his people). Because they broke this covenant, judgment would follow.

As a result, the land would become desolate (empty and ruined).

Ezekiel 16:1–3

Ezekiel begins by describing Jerusalem's weak and unlikely beginnings. He says the city came from Canaanite roots and was like the child of an Amorite father and a Hittite mother.

The city existed long before Israel entered the land under Joshua. During Joshua's campaign, Israel did not fully capture Jerusalem. The city remained in the hands of its original Canaanite population.

Later, King David captured Jerusalem and made it his capital. Even then, the city had a long Canaanite history before it became the center of Israel's kingdom.

Ezekiel 16:1–63

In Ezekiel 16, Jerusalem is described as an unfaithful wife and a prostitute. This language is very strong. Even in English, the chapter can be difficult to read. In its ancient setting, it would have sounded even more shocking.

Ezekiel used graphic language to show how serious Judah's sin was. He did not try to make his message softer or more polite. He spoke in a direct and forceful way.

This strong language is the main point of the chapter. Ezekiel wanted the people to feel how terrible their sin was in God's sight. The shocking description helped them understand that God's judgment was not unfair.

If Ezekiel had used softer words, the people might not have understood the full seriousness of their sin. The strong picture was necessary to show why God's judgment was justified (that is, right and fair).

Ezekiel 16:4–5

Jerusalem's parents are described as cruel and uncaring. They did not care for her when she was born. They did not do the normal things people did to help a newborn baby.

Usually, someone cut the umbilical cord. They washed the baby. They rubbed salt and oil on the child's skin to clean and protect her. Then they wrapped the baby tightly in cloth to keep her warm and safe.

But none of this happened to Jerusalem. Instead, she was thrown into an open field and left there. In the ancient world, people often abandoned baby girls in this way. She was left alone to die.

Ezekiel 16:6–7

Jerusalem was helpless and close to death. She had no one to protect her. At that moment, the Lord stepped in and spoke a life-giving word. Without his word, she would have died.

The Lord did not owe this abandoned child anything. Many other children in the ancient world were left to die. He was not required to rescue her. But because of his grace and mercy (his undeserved kindness and compassion), he chose to save her.

The Lord did more than keep her alive. He helped her grow strong. Instead of dying in the field, she grew like a healthy plant. She became mature and beautiful.

The city of Jerusalem became strong and successful even before it was an Israelite city. This growth did not happen by accident. It was the Lord's work.

Ezekiel 16:8

At this point, the Lord covered her with his cloak. In the ancient world, this action showed a promise of marriage (compare Ruth 3:9). It was a sign that he was taking her as his own.

The Lord then made a covenant with Jerusalem. In the picture Ezekiel uses, this covenant is like a marriage. The Lord chose her and joined himself to her.

Later, the Lord made a covenant with David and his descendants. At that time, he also chose Jerusalem as the place where his name would be honored (see 1 Kings 9:3–4; Psalm 132). Jerusalem became the special city connected to his presence and worship.

Ezekiel 16:9–10

- The Lord did for Jerusalem what her parents never did: he washed, anointed, and clothed her, reversing the circumstances of her birth.
- The Lord gave Jerusalem beautiful gifts. He dressed her with ornaments and fine materials fit for a

queen. Some of these same materials were used in the tabernacle (see Exodus 25:3–5; 26:1–14).

This detail would remind the people of Jerusalem of something important. Their city was chosen as the place for God's sanctuary and the king's palace. The Lord honored Jerusalem by making her the center of worship and royal rule.

Ezekiel 16:11–14

She wore jewelry and ate the finest foods. She was known throughout the world for her beauty and splendor, which were gifts from the Lord.

Ezekiel 16:15–19

Jerusalem did not appreciate the good things God gave her. She used her fame and beauty for false gods. She offered clothes, jewels, food, and oil to idols instead of honoring God.

Ezekiel 16:20–22

Jerusalem even sacrificed her sons and daughters to false gods. The nations around Israel practiced child sacrifice to show total commitment to a deity. This was common in the worship of the gods Molech and Chemosh (see Deuteronomy 12:31; 2 Kings 3:27). Israel sometimes took part in this terrible sin.

Ezekiel 16:23–25

The prophets often described idolatry (worshiping false gods) as adultery (being unfaithful in marriage). For example, Hosea uses this picture to explain Israel's sin (see Hosea 2). This comparison helped people understand that turning away from the Lord was like breaking a marriage promise.

Ezekiel, however, gives much more detail than the other prophets. He does not describe Jerusalem as only confused or mistaken. He describes her as deeply corrupt. Her unfaithfulness took place openly, on every street corner.

Ezekiel also says that her desire for sin had no limit. She kept seeking more sinful and shameful practices. His strong language shows how serious her idolatry had become.

Ezekiel 16:26–29

Jerusalem eagerly sought close relationships with Egypt, Assyria, and Babylonia. These political alliances cost a great deal of money. They also failed to bring the help and protection that the leaders expected.

Even if these agreements had brought clear political benefits, they would still have been wrong. They showed that Jerusalem did not trust the Lord. Instead of depending on him, the city looked to other nations for safety.

These alliances also led to another serious problem. Israel began to worship the gods of those nations. Political dependence slowly became spiritual unfaithfulness.

Ezekiel 16:35–38

Because Jerusalem acted like an unfaithful spouse, it was appropriate for her to face a similar punishment. God would symbolically strip her of her dignity, reversing the marriage metaphor of being clothed (see Ezekiel 16:8; Hosea 2:2–3).

Then the people would stone her (Leviticus 20:10; Deuteronomy 22:22). Since this would cover her naked body with blood, she would leave the world just as she came into it. This metaphor was fulfilled when the Babylonians destroyed the city in 586 BC.

Ezekiel 16:39–43

In a tragic turn, the nations that Jerusalem trusted would later attack her. The very allies she depended on would turn against her and destroy her.

The Lord's anger would continue until justice was complete. It would not end until Jerusalem had paid the full price for her past sins. Only then would his judgment be finished.

Ezekiel 16:44–45

Jerusalem's "parents" were a Hittite and an Amorite. Hittites and Amorites were previous occupants of Canaan who were cut off from the land because of their sins (compare Genesis 15:16). The pagan city of Jerusalem was captured and became part of Israel during David's time (2 Samuel 5:6–10). Jerusalem's later actions matched her family background. She behaved in a way that fit her heredity (family line and ancestry).

In other words, her conduct was consistent with where she came from. Her actions reflected the character of her origins.

Ezekiel 16:46–50

- Samaria, Jerusalem's older (or larger) sister, engaged in improper worship since Jeroboam introduced golden calves at the national shrines in Dan and Bethel (1 Kings 12:28–33).

- Sodom, Jerusalem's younger (or smaller) sister, became known for sexual sin (Genesis 19:4–9) and for pride, gluttony, laziness, and neglect of the poor and needy.

Ezekiel 16:51–52

Compared to Jerusalem, Samaria and Sodom seemed good. If God rightly destroyed both of Jerusalem's sisters for their sins, how could Jerusalem avoid God's coming anger?

Ezekiel 16:53–54

God's grace, more than his judgment, would make Jerusalem ashamed of her ties to such "parents" and "sisters" (Ezekiel 16:44–52).

Ezekiel 16:59–63

Jerusalem's sins were serious and required judgment. But judgment was not God's final word on Jerusalem. She had broken God's covenant in many ways. Because of this, she deserved the penalty of death.

But judgment was not God's final word. The Lord would remember the covenant he made with her at the beginning. His plans for his people could not be stopped, even by their sin. His covenant commitment lasts forever (Psalm 136).

In the end, God would forgive her sins. His forgiveness would lead Jerusalem to repentance.

Ezekiel 17:1–24

This chapter includes a riddle. A riddle is a type of metaphorical speech (language that uses pictures and comparisons). It both hides and shows the meaning at the same time.

The chapter is also a fable. A fable is a story that teaches a moral lesson. It often tells the lesson through plants or animals instead of people.

This creative setting creates distance between the story and real life. That distance helps the listener receive the message. It lowers resistance to a message that may be hard or unpleasant to hear.

Ezekiel 17:3–6

Babylon was the city filled with merchants (see Ezekiel 16:29).

Ezekiel 17:7–9

- There was a second great eagle. It was like the first eagle, but it was not as impressive or powerful.
- The future of the vine was easy to foresee. In trying to gain more, it would lose what it already had. Its desire for more would bring loss instead of gain.

The second eagle would not help the vine. At the same time, the first eagle would become angry. That anger would be justified because the vine had been unfaithful.

Ezekiel 17:10

In Judah, the east wind blows from the desert and is therefore hot and dry.

Ezekiel 17:11–18

- The first eagle represents Nebuchadnezzar, king of Babylon. The cedar sprig represents Jehoiachin, whom Nebuchadnezzar took away to Babylon. The plant that later grew into a low vine represents Zedekiah. The second eagle represents Egypt. Zedekiah asked Egypt for help because he wanted to break free from Babylon's rule.

The hot east wind represents judgment from Babylon. This wind pulled up and dried out Jerusalem. In other words, Babylon destroyed the city as an act of judgment.

- The picture of the eagle caring for the vine may describe God's care for Israel more than Nebuchadnezzar's concern for Zedekiah. This comparison shows an important lesson. Zedekiah rebelled against his overlord (the king who ruled over him), Nebuchadnezzar. In a similar way, Israel rebelled against the Lord.

Zedekiah's rebellion against Babylon was extremely foolish. It led to destruction and death. Israel's rebellion against the Lord, the God of heaven and earth, was even more foolish.

Ezekiel 17:19–21

- God would punish Israel's king because he broke his covenant. By turning against Babylon, he also committed treason (betrayal against a ruler). In doing this, he sinned against the Lord, who had placed him in the promised land.
- will bring him to Babylon and execute judgment upon him: See 2 Kings 25:5–7.

Ezekiel 17:22–24

- The last part of the chapter changes the story. Now the Lord takes a branch from the cedar tree and plants it on Israel's highest mountain. In the Old Testament, a tree often represents a royal family

line. A new shoot (a small new branch) represents a new beginning (compare Isaiah 11:1).

The judgment on the vine would not end the monarchy (the rule of kings). God would plant a new branch. This branch would grow into a greater cedar than the first one. Although the line of kings seemed to end with Zedekiah, this was not the final outcome.
In God's time, a new beginning was certain (see Haggai 2:21–23; Matthew 1:11–16; 2:1–11).

- God cuts down the tall tree, makes the short tree grow tall, and revives the dead tree, allowing birds of every kind to find shelter and shade under its branches. In this picture, birds of every kind represent the nations.

God had promised David an eternal throne (a kingdom that would not end). The failures of David's descendants, the kings of Judah, could not cancel that promise. One day, the family line of David would rise again. This happened through Jesus, who brings blessing to all nations.

Ezekiel 18:1–2

The fathers have eaten sour grapes, and the teeth of the children are set on edge: The people were repeating a proverb. This meant that innocent children sometimes suffer for their parents' actions.

In Ezekiel's time, the people used this saying to make a complaint. They believed that their ancestors had committed the sins that caused the exile. They thought they were suffering for sins they did not commit (compare Lamentations 5:7).

Ezekiel 18:3–4

The Lord's response to the proverb of Ezekiel 18:1–2 was to clearly state that it did not apply to this situation. Instead, the Lord always punishes only the guilty (Deuteronomy 24:16). God is always fair and just.

Ezekiel 18:5–9

God's justice is shown through a case study of three imagined generations. In the first generation, a righteous man faithfully worships the Lord, stays sexually pure, and treats others fairly. A person who lives this way does not need to fear God's judgment.

Ezekiel 18:6

does not ... approach a woman during her period: See study note on Ezekiel 36:17; see also Leviticus 15.

Ezekiel 18:7

Borrowers might need to provide objects as security to ensure loan repayment. However, if the object was an outer garment, which might be a poor man's only valuable possession, it had to be returned before nightfall so he could stay warm at night (see Exodus 22:26–27).

Ezekiel 18:8

Lending money with interest to those in need was banned because it tempted lenders to exploit borrowers (see Exodus 22:25).

Ezekiel 18:10–13

If the son of a righteous man (a man who lives in a right way before God) does not follow God's ways or his father's example, he is responsible for his own sin. If his life is completely different from what his father believed and practiced, he will bear his own guilt. He will face God's judgment for his own actions.

Ezekiel 18:14–18

The righteous son of an evil man will surely live. God will judge each person individually.

Ezekiel 18:21–24

Ezekiel gives two more examples.

First, wicked people (those who do evil) who turn away from their sins can receive God's forgiveness.

Second, righteous people (those who live in a right way before God) who begin to sin will face judgment.

Ezekiel 18:23–24

God does not want wicked people to die. He made Ezekiel a watchman to guide the wicked toward a godly life and to warn the righteous not to stray (Ezekiel 3:16–19; 33:1–9).

Ezekiel 18:25–29

Israel's issue was not that the Lord was unjust, but that they kept doing wrong. They fully deserved God's judgment.

Ezekiel 18:30–32

This chapter ends with a strong appeal to the people of Israel. God calls them to turn back to him and live.

It was not too late for them to repent. They could turn from their sins and receive forgiveness. God promised to give them a new heart and a new spirit (Ezekiel 11:19; 36:26).

A new heart and a new spirit mean an inner change. God would change their thoughts and desires. He would do this for all who turned from their rebellion and came to him with humility.

Ezekiel 19:1–14

- In the ancient Near East, a funeral song had a special rhythm and style. It usually praised the good qualities of the person who had died. It also compared past glory with the present loss.

In this chapter, however, the people being mourned were not yet dead. The song does not praise them. Instead, it lists their sins and failures. This funeral song clearly shows that their judgment was certain and explains why it would happen.

- The lion (Ezekiel 19:2–9) and the vine (19:10–14) were common pictures for Israel's princes and for the royal family of Judah. These images would have been familiar to the people who first heard this message.

Ezekiel 19:2–4

- The first picture shows a lioness and one of her cubs, whom she chose as the leader of her group. This cub represents Jehoahaz, who ruled for only three months before Pharaoh Neco took him to Egypt (2 Kings 23:33–34).
- tear his prey … devoured men: The prophet describes Jehoahaz's short reign in completely negative terms. He presents his rule as evil and harmful.
- In ancient times, hunters often caught lions with a net and a pit. In this passage, that picture is a metaphor for what would happen to Jehoahaz. He would be captured and taken away to Egypt by force.

Ezekiel 19:5–7

The second cub acted like the first one, but he was even more violent. He destroyed towns and cities.

This cub may represent Jehoiakim, Jehoiachin, or Zedekiah. The text does not clearly say which one.

It is also not clear which towns and cities were destroyed. The prophet may be describing the harmful results of the king's foolish foreign policy (his decisions about relationships with other nations). These choices brought suffering to the towns and cities of Judah.

Ezekiel 19:8–9

The Babylonians captured and killed Jehoiakim in Judah. They exiled Jehoiachin and Ezekiel to Babylon. Zedekiah's rule ended when Jerusalem was destroyed in 586 BC.

Ezekiel 19:10

The vine clearly represents Judah, whom the Lord had planted and cared for in the best possible conditions.

Ezekiel 19:11–12

Judah's pride led to its fall. The Lord removed the nation in his anger (compare Ezekiel 17:1–10). He then placed Judah in exile. Exile is life away from the land God had given them. It was like being planted in a dry desert.

Ezekiel 19:13–14

The fire that came from the vine's own branches probably represents Zedekiah. That fire burned up the fruit. The fruit represents the land and the people.

After this destruction, no strong branch remained. There was no branch able to become a ruler's scepter (a symbol of kingly authority). Zedekiah would not have an immediate successor.

Ezekiel 20:1–3

- In the seventh year of King Jehoiachin's captivity, five more years remained before Jerusalem's destruction.
- The leaders (literally elders) of Israel, who were the community's elders in exile, came to Ezekiel again, seeking a message from the Lord (compare Ezekiel 8:1; 14:1).

Normally, it is good to seek a message from the Lord. But these leaders had already been judged because their motives were divided (see Ezekiel 14). They did not truly seek God with sincere hearts.

Because of this, the Lord refused to answer them. The text does not record the question they planned to ask Ezekiel. It is possible they never had the chance to ask it.

Ezekiel 20:4–26

The Lord refused to answer their question. But this did not mean he had nothing to say.

Instead, God gave them a different message through Ezekiel. Ezekiel would describe the sinful and detestable actions of their ancestors. He would place these past sins clearly before the people.

Ezekiel 20:8–21

Each generation of Israelites rebelled against the Lord. They refused to obey the commandments he gave them.

Each time, the Lord warned that he would pour out his fury (his strong anger) on them (Ezekiel 20:8, 13, 21). But he held back his judgment. He did this for the honor of his name.

If he had destroyed them, the surrounding nations might have thought he was too weak to bring his people into the promised land.

Ezekiel 20:23

Israel had a long history of refusing to obey the Lord's decrees and regulations. Because of this, God decided to scatter them among the nations. He sent them away from their land and spread them among many different peoples.

Ezekiel 20:25–26

I also gave them over to statutes that were not good and ordinances ... I pronounced them unclean: This means that the Lord allowed the people of Israel to follow their own sinful desires. He did not stop them from choosing false worship and harmful practices.

They took part in the complex and corrupt rituals of paganism (the worship of false gods). As a result, they suffered the painful consequences of their sins (see Romans 1:18–25).

Ezekiel 20:26

The Israelites even offered their firstborn children as sacrifices to the god Molech. This was a terrible sin.

This action reversed what God had done in the exodus. At that time, the Lord called Israel his "firstborn son" (Exodus 4:22). He rescued them from slavery so they could worship him in purity in the promised land.

Instead of honoring the Lord, they gave their children to a false god. Their actions showed how far they had turned away from him.

Ezekiel 20:27–31

When they reached the promised land, the people of Israel continued to speak against and betray the Lord. Their idol worship and wickedness persisted until Ezekiel's time. The Lord would not answer such unfaithful people.

Ezekiel 20:32–38

- In the past, Israel rebelled against God. Because of this, God judged them in limited ways. As a result, they were scattered among other nations again.

However, judgment was not the end of the story. Earlier events in Israel's history showed that God does not forget his promises. God's own honor required him to keep his covenant with his people, even when they sinned.

- Israel could never become like the surrounding nations who worship idols made of wood and stone (Ezekiel 20:32). God had chosen Israel to belong to him. Because of this, he would gather them again.

God said he would bring them into the wilderness, as he did in the first exodus from Egypt. This would be like a new exodus. But this was not only good news. After the first exodus, an entire generation died in the wilderness because of their sin. In the same way, God would judge this new generation. He would remove those who continued to rebel and refuse to obey him. Those rebels would not enter the land of Israel. The wilderness among the nations would become their final resting place.

Ezekiel 20:39–44

The people of Israel might continue to worship idols for a time. However, in the end, they would worship God in spirit and in truth on his holy mountain (see Ezekiel 40–48, where the purified worship of God is restored in the temple). Jesus also spoke about worshiping the Father in spirit and in truth (John 4:21–24).

God chose Israel to be a holy nation. His purpose in choosing them would not fail. In the end, his plan would stand.

The people would become like a pleasing sacrifice to God. This does not mean they would be killed. It means their lives would fully belong to him. Through them, God's holiness would be clearly seen.

This new exodus would lead to pure worship. A purified people would offer that worship. God would save them by his sovereign grace (his rule and undeserved kindness).

Ezekiel 20:45–49

Like a parable, this prophecy both reveals and conceals its message. People complain that the prophet only speaks in riddles (see Matthew 13:10–17). It reveals that a powerful judgment is coming. This judgment is described as an all-consuming fire. That means it is like a fire that burns up every tree.

Ezekiel 20:46

- set your face toward the south (literally turn toward Teman): Teman was a town in Edom, southeast of Judah.
- The Negev was southwest of the Dead Sea.

Ezekiel 20:47

A green tree usually does not burn easily, but a dry tree catches fire quickly. This judgment fire would be so intense that it would burn all types of trees.

Ezekiel 21:1–32

This chapter repeatedly mentions a sword (Ezekiel 21:3–5, 9, 11–12, 14–16, 19, 28–30). Each time, the sword represents God's judgment.

Ezekiel 21:3–5

- The Lord himself was the true enemy Israel needed to fear. He was about to bring a complete judgment against them.
- Normally, people expect the righteous to escape judgment and the wicked to receive it. This contrast is like the green tree and the dry tree in the parable (Ezekiel 20:47–48).

God's judgment on sin would be like a very hot fire. It would burn everything it touched.

Ezekiel 21:6–7

Ezekiel's groaning showed that in the coming judgment, even the bravest would feel fear and the strong would become weak. The judgment that had been announced was now a harsh reality (compare Ezekiel 7:1–4).

Ezekiel 21:8–11

sword, sharpened and polished: These actions prepare the weapon to be deadly and effective.

Once the sword is ready, it will be given to the executioner (the one who carries out a death sentence). He will use it against God's people.

Ezekiel 21:12

Cry out and wail: Ezekiel would represent the people's response to the judgment.

Ezekiel 21:14–17

As the Lord's representative, Ezekiel was to clap his hands in a threatening way and wave the sword three times. This action symbolized the complete massacre to come.

There would be no place to escape. No one could hide from the sword of judgment. When the Lord was ready to act, he would destroy his people. In this way, he would satisfy his fury (his burning anger). They would be filled with terror. Their courage would disappear.

Ezekiel 21:18–20

The sword of the Lord was not just a symbol. It would become the sword of the king of Babylon.

That king was Nebuchadnezzar. His army would carry out God's judgment.

Ezekiel showed this in a visual way. He drew a map to show the king's two possible targets. One was Rabbah, the capital of Ammon. The other was Jerusalem, the capital of Judah.

Ezekiel 21:21

- Omens were signs that people believed came from the gods. People looked for these signs through divination (trying to learn the future through special rituals).
- He shakes the arrows, he consults the idols, he examines the liver: These were common ways people tried to receive omens from their gods.

Ezekiel 21:23–24

A treaty with the Babylonians would not save the people of Jerusalem because they had broken its terms. The king of Babylon would remind them of their rebellion. He would show in public that rebelling against a covenant overlord (a powerful ruler who made a binding agreement) brings serious consequences. If rebellion against their Babylonian ruler brought punishment, how much more would rebellion against the Lord bring judgment?

Ezekiel 21:25–27

- This judgment would affect Zedekiah, the corrupt and wicked leader of Israel, and the people. Ezekiel refers to Zedekiah by his title, showing that his position was also judged. He would lose his royal symbols and be humbled, while the Lord would lift up the humble. The old order would face destruction.
- the arrival of Him ... to whom I have assigned the right of judgment: Many people understand this coming judge to be the Messiah (God's chosen one), as in Genesis 49:10. In this context, however, the Lord was giving Judah to the Babylonians for judgment (see Ezekiel 23:24).

Ezekiel was likely reshaping the traditional promise in Genesis 49:10. Instead of pointing to a future king,

he applied it to a coming judgment. Nebuchadnezzar would act as God's instrument. God would take the scepter (symbol of royal rule) away from Judah for a time because its rulers had sinned. Later, God would restore it.

Ezekiel 21:28–29

The Ammonites should not have celebrated when Nebuchadnezzar chose to go to Jerusalem instead of Rabbah (Ezekiel 21:18–20). They were also among the wicked facing judgment day.

Ezekiel 21:30–32

The sword would return to its sheath. This does not mean it would rest. It would return in order to carry out the Lord's judgment against its own land, Babylon.

God would also pour out his fury and the fire of his anger on Babylon. These words describe God's intense judgment. Babylon did not receive special protection just because God had used it to judge other nations.

Judgment may have begun with God's household (1 Peter 4:17), but it did not stop there. God's judgment also included the surrounding nations that did not worship him.

Ezekiel 22:1–5

Now God called Ezekiel to speak like a prosecutor in a court. He announced the charges against Jerusalem that would lead to its judgment.

The people were guilty of sins against other people. They had shed innocent blood (see Genesis 9:5–6). They were also guilty of sins against God. They made idols, which God had forbidden (see Exodus 20:4–6).

These two kinds of sin made the city unclean. They made Jerusalem guilty and deserving of judgment. The people were no longer fit to stand before the holy God. As a result, Jerusalem faced certain destruction and shame.

Ezekiel 22:1–31

Jerusalem was the holy city where God had placed his name. It was the spiritual center of Judah. The city represented God's presence among his people.

But Jerusalem had become corrupt and unclean. Instead of honoring God, the city was full of violence and bloodshed. Because of this sin, God's wrath (his just anger against sin) would come upon the city.

Ezekiel 22:6–12

The charges against the people of Judah and their leaders came from God's law, especially from Leviticus 18–20; 25:1–55. Israel's many sins showed a failure to honor and trust the Lord and his commands. This unfaithfulness to their covenant with the Lord could lead to only one outcome: The people of Israel would face the covenant curses (Deuteronomy 8:19–20; 28:15–68).

Ezekiel 22:7

the foreign resident is exploited: Compare Exodus 22:21; 23:9; Leviticus 19:33–34; Deuteronomy 10:18–19.

Ezekiel 22:10

- nakedness of their fathers: See Leviticus 18:7–8.
- they violate women during their menstrual impurity: See Leviticus 15:19–24.

Ezekiel 22:13–16

God first showed his anger with the image of clapping his hands. This action expressed strong displeasure. Then he announced that he would pour out judgment.

The first judgment was exile. God would scatter the people of Judah among other nations. Through this scattering, God would remove their wickedness and cleanse them from sin.

Ezekiel 22:16

when you have defiled yourself in the eyes of the nations: The Lord's people were scattered among the nations instead of living in the promised land. This situation made it seem like the Lord could not fulfill his promise. However, the Lord was willing to endure this dishonor so his forgetful people could learn to remember him.

Ezekiel 22:17–22

Scattering was not the only part of God's judgment. God would also gather the people of Judah into Jerusalem for judgment.

The prophet compared this gathering to metal placed into a furnace (a very hot oven used to melt metal). A worker gathers pieces of metal and puts them into the fire to melt and refine them.

But this fire would not make the people pure. Normally, a furnace removes waste material and leaves pure metal. In this case, the people were like worthless slag (waste left over after metal is melted). Since only waste would go into the fire, only melted waste would come out.

This judgment would not cleanse or restore the people. It would destroy everything in its path.

Ezekiel 22:23–24

Jerusalem had already faced judgment, but it did not lead to change. The city remained polluted (morally and spiritually unclean).

Ezekiel 22:25–29

- This list of Jerusalem's sins focuses on the wrongdoings of Judah's leaders (compare Zephaniah 3:3–4).
- princes: The princes and other leaders abused their power by killing innocent people and taking their wealth. The priests sinned by failing to teach the law, preventing people from distinguishing between holy and unholy, clean and unclean. The prophets shared false visions instead of true messages from God. As a result, the people wandered away from God because they had no guidance.

Ezekiel 22:30–31

Because of the sins of these former community leaders, the Lord looked for someone to rebuild the wall and act as a true prophet (see Ezekiel 13:5). This person would intercede for the people, like Moses did after they sinned with the golden calf (Exodus 32). The Lord found no one to turn away his wrath. So he would pour out his fury on the people completely (compare Ezekiel 11:21).

Ezekiel 23:1–49

This chapter, like chapter 16, tells the history of the northern and southern kingdoms of Israel and Judah. It does this through an extended metaphor (a comparison that continues through many verses).

In this comparison, Samaria and Jerusalem, the capital cities, are described as two immoral women. The language is strong and direct.

This metaphor shows that their judgment was certain and deserved.

Ezekiel 23:2

daughters of the same mother: They came from the same nation, and their lives were very similar. Even their names, Oholah and Oholibah, sound alike.

Ezekiel 23:3

They became prostitutes by worshiping false gods.

Ezekiel 23:4

Marriage is commonly used in the Bible as a symbol for the covenant relationship between God and his people (for example, Isaiah 54:1–8; Ephesians 5:22–33). Adultery symbolizes Israel's spiritual unfaithfulness (for example, Hosea 1–3). God makes his covenants even though his people are sinful. He does not choose them because of their good character (Romans 5:6–11).

Ezekiel 23:5–8

Oholah: The northern kingdom did not embrace God's covenant of grace. Instead, it was drawn to Assyria's power and prestige. Israel formed alliances with Assyria as part of its political strategy starting in the 800s BC. However, these alliances did not protect Israel in the end.

Ezekiel 23:9–10

The Assyrian army conquered the northern kingdom in 722 BC, scattering its people across the Assyrian Empire.

Ezekiel 23:11–18

Samaria's reputation and punishment were known to everyone in Ezekiel's time. Her sister, Oholibah (Jerusalem), followed the same pattern of life and was even worse than her sister. The kings of Judah thought it was wise to form alliances with Babylon and Assyria. However, the prophet saw this as a pattern of ongoing spiritual unfaithfulness.

Ezekiel 23:19–20

When the people of Jerusalem thought of Egypt, they did not remember how the Lord freed them during the exodus. Instead, they recalled the forbidden pleasures they had enjoyed there.

Ezekiel 23:22–24

Jerusalem's sin was very great. Because of this, God's judgment could not be avoided.

The same nations that Jerusalem had trusted and depended on would now attack her. Babylon would come with its allies, Pekod, Shoa, and Koa.

These tribal names are not well-known. However, they sound like Hebrew words that mean "punishment," "war cry," and "shriek" (a loud cry of fear or pain).

Judah's sins were worse than those of her sister kingdom. So her punishment would also be worse.

Ezekiel 23:25–29

In the ancient world, people sometimes punished an adulterous wife by stripping her naked. This public act exposed in public what she had done in private (her unfaithfulness in marriage). This was meant to bring shame as punishment for adultery (see study note on Ezekiel 16:35–38).

In a similar way, the Babylonians took away everything valuable from Jerusalem and Judah. They left the people exposed and ashamed before other nations.

Ezekiel 23:31–34

You will drink your sister's cup: Jerusalem would have to drink from this bitter cup of judgment, just like Samaria did. The pain from this judgment would make her beat (or tear) her breast in anguish.

Ezekiel 23:36–43

The prophet again took the role of a prosecuting attorney. A prosecuting attorney is a person who brings charges against someone in court. His task was to confront Jerusalem with her sins (detailed in Ezekiel 22).

Jerusalem and Samaria were supposed to be holy cities, set apart for God. Instead, they had become like worn-out prostitutes. This picture shows that they had been unfaithful to God. Their only attraction was their availability, meaning they were ready to give themselves to anyone.

The prophet used this strong image to show how serious their unfaithfulness was. They had turned away from the Lord and given their loyalty to other gods and foreign nations.

Ezekiel 23:44–49

The sisters' enemies would attack them with stones and swords, like an invading army. In a typical invasion, not only would the prostitutes die, but their sons and daughters would also die. The enemy would burn their homes. Those who rebelled against the Lord and followed false gods would face death as punishment.

Ezekiel 24:1–14

At first, the picture of a cooking pot seems positive. It makes people think about good food and shared meals. In many cultures, a meal brings people together in peace and joy.

The pot was filled with choice pieces of meat from a sacrifice. A fire burned under the pot. The meat began to cook slowly.

However, like many parables, this story has a sharp ending. What should have been a good meal became rotten and unclean. The best pieces of meat went into the pot, but they came out spoiled.

The pot represents Jerusalem (Ezekiel 24:9). The meat inside represents the people. Instead of being pure and pleasing to God, they had become corrupt (morally ruined). As a result, the pot and its contents would be burned and destroyed.

Ezekiel 24:2

- Ezekiel had warned the people about this event, and it had finally happened (see also 2 Kings 25:1–2).
- has laid siege (literally is leaning on): The same words were used when a worshiper placed his hands on the animal he brought for sacrifice (Leviticus 1:4; 3:2).

When the worshiper pressed his hands on the animal, he showed that the animal was taking his place.
In this picture, Jerusalem is like that animal. The city is shown as a sacrificial lamb that will be killed. Its destruction would display God's glory and justice.

Ezekiel 24:3

The people of Jerusalem had rebelled against their treaty with Babylon. A treaty is a formal agreement between two nations.

They had also broken their covenant with the Lord. A covenant is a solemn promise or binding agreement between God and his people.

By breaking both agreements, they showed that they were unfaithful to human rulers and to God.

Ezekiel 24:6–8

The cooking pot was too dirty to clean. Jerusalem was full of blood that she had shed and left uncovered. The Old Testament required that people cover the blood of animals killed for meat with earth (Leviticus 17:13). By leaving the blood of innocent victims uncovered, Jerusalem was doubly guilty. Her own blood would rightly be splashed on the rocks (compare Psalm 137:8–9).

Ezekiel 24:9–12

God said he would make Jerusalem like a red-hot cooking pot, as if it were in a refiner's furnace. However, even this fire would not remove its corruption, because Jerusalem's impurity was permanent.

Ezekiel 24:13–14

Jerusalem faced judgment without mercy due to her evil actions and refusal to return to the Lord.

Ezekiel 24:15–17

Nowhere do we see a prophet so deeply involved in his message as in this event. God took the life of Ezekiel's wife. Yet Ezekiel was not allowed to mourn her openly, even though she was very precious to him.

Ezekiel was a priest (Ezekiel 1:3). Priests had strict rules about mourning. When people mourned, they often tore their clothes and left their hair uncombed. These public signs of grief made a person ceremonially unclean (not fit for worship).

Priests were not allowed to make themselves unclean, except for their closest family members (Leviticus 21:1–4). Even so, God told Ezekiel not to follow the usual customs of mourning.

Ezekiel's silence was a sign act (a symbolic action that carries a message). It showed what would soon happen to Israel (Ezekiel 24:20–24; see "Prophetic Sign Acts" Theme Note). The people would lose something precious, but they would not be able to mourn in the normal way.

Ezekiel 24:20–24

Ezekiel's lack of mourning (Ezekiel 24:15–17) was a sign to Israel about their future. The Lord was about to take away the temple of Jerusalem, the place they cherished. God would desecrate it and destroy the sons and daughters left in Jerusalem.

On that day, the people would act like Ezekiel. They would not mourn publicly or perform rituals. Although they would feel deep loss, the devastation would be so great that normal mourning rites would be impossible. In such complete desolation, only internal grief would be possible.

Ezekiel 24:25–27

During this deep gloom and sorrow, when a survivor confirmed the fall of Jerusalem, there would be a sign of hope. On that day, Ezekiel's voice would return (see Ezekiel 3:26), allowing him to pray to God for the people and intercede for them. The final destruction of Jerusalem would mark the complete outpouring of God's wrath and fury. On that day, Ezekiel would speak words of hope to the shattered exiles, helping them know the Lord.

Ezekiel 25:1–32.32

- This section contains a series of messages of judgment against nearby nations. There are six shorter messages against Judah's immediate neighbors, arranged in a clockwise order, followed by a final message against Egypt (Ezekiel 30–32). Through experiencing God's judgment, the nations would recognize God's control over everything. The nations might be used to carry out God's judgment on his people, but they would not avoid judgment themselves.
- One of the main purposes of these messages was to show that the negative part of God's promise to Abraham ("I will ... curse those who curse you," Genesis 12:3) was still active. No one can harm God's people and avoid consequences, even when God's people are under his judgment.

Ezekiel 25:3–7

The Ammonites celebrated Judah's downfall and the destruction of Israel's temple. So, as the prophet warned (Ezekiel 21:28–32), they would face invasion and destruction. Others would consume the Ammonites' produce, and their people would be wiped out, similar to Judah. The Ammonites' gods could not save them from the Lord's anger, and they would realize that the Lord is the true God.

Ezekiel 25:8–11

The people of Moab believed they could attack Judah without punishment. They treated Judah as if it were just another nation.

This was not true. Judah had been acting like the other nations (see Ezekiel 20:32). However, Judah was different because it had a covenant with God.

God would not finally reject Judah. He would discipline his people, but he would not abandon them forever.

Moab, however, would face judgment. Like Ammon, Moab would be removed from the register of the nations (the official list of recognized nations). It would be left desolate (empty and ruined) forever.

Ezekiel 25:12–14

- Ammon and Moab were happy about Judah's downfall, but Edom actively took part in it (see Ezekiel 35:5; Obadiah 1).
- vengefully: The people of Edom captured those fleeing and handed over survivors to help the Babylonians (Obadiah 1:11–14). They were opportunists, settling old conflicts from the ancient feud between Jacob and Esau (Genesis 27:41). They took what they

could from Judah's suffering. In return, the Lord would destroy their land.

Ezekiel 25:15–17

- The Philistines had a long-standing dislike for Judah. Their specific wrongdoings are not mentioned, but the Lord noticed them and would seek revenge. They would then understand the Lord's supreme power.
- The Kerethites were a Philistine tribe (see 1 Samuel 30:14).

Ezekiel 26:1

February 3, 585 BC was about seven months after the fall of Jerusalem.

Ezekiel 26:1–28.19

The message against Tyre, Israel's northwestern neighbor, is more detailed than the short messages before it. It consists of three similar sections (Ezekiel 26:2–21; 27:1–36; and 28:1–19). Each section conveys the same idea: Tyre would meet a terrible end and cease to exist (Ezekiel 27:36).

Ezekiel 26:2

Like its neighbors, Tyre celebrated when Jerusalem fell. This event removed a competing trade center and possibly opened new trade routes and markets for Tyre.

Ezekiel 26:3–6

- The nations Tyre wanted to trade with would instead attack her, prepared for war. Like Jerusalem, she would become loot for their armies.
- as the sea brings up its waves: This image fits Tyre very well. Tyre was built on a small island along the coast. Waves were a normal part of life there.

The picture shows how enemies would strike Tyre again and again, like waves hitting the shore. It is a metaphor (a word picture) for a military assault.

Ezekiel 26:7–11

The detailed description of Tyre's expected destruction shows confidence in the conflict's outcome.

Ezekiel 26:12–14

In the end, events happened just as the prophet had described earlier in picture language (metaphor). Tyre would become a bare rock. It would no longer be a great and wealthy city.

Instead of being a busy center for ships and caravans from the east, it would become a quiet place. Local fishermen would spread their nets there to dry (Ezekiel 26:2). The great trading city would become empty and ruined.

The Jewish historian Josephus wrote that Nebuchadnezzar besieged Tyre for 13 years. However, Tyre was not completely destroyed at that time.

It was finally destroyed later by Alexander the Great in 332 BC.

Ezekiel 26:15–16

The fall of Tyre would not affect Tyre alone. It would also harm the cities and nations that traded with her.

Tyre was an important center for trade along the coast. Many rulers depended on her for wealth and goods. When Tyre fell, the economic impact (financial damage) would spread along the whole coastline.

Because of this loss, some rulers would abdicate (give up their rule and step down from power).

Ezekiel 26:17–18

- A funeral song would be sung for Tyre. This kind of song is called a lament (a song of mourning for the dead). The prophet had used this kind of song earlier (see study note on Ezekiel 19:1–14). People would repeat this funeral song from place to place. Many would mourn the fall of the great city.
- powerful on the sea ... who imposed terror: Tyre had strong naval power (military strength at sea). Her ships traveled widely and controlled important trade routes.

Because of this power, Tyre spread fear among other nations. Her trading system was not always peaceful. It was often based on conquest (defeating others in war), subjugation (forcing others to submit), and exploitation (using others unfairly for gain). See Ezekiel 28:16, 18.

Ezekiel 26:19–21

God would show his sovereign power by completely destroying Tyre.

It would be as if the great city had sunk beneath the deep waters of the sea. This picture describes total ruin. The people of Tyre would go down to the pit (the place of the dead), where the wicked dead remain. They would never return.

Ezekiel 27:1–36

The second part of the prophet's message to Tyre (see study note on Ezekiel 26:1–28:19) is a funeral song.

The song compares Tyre's past glory with its present loss. It connects with the previous chapter in several ways. Both speak directly to Tyre. Both describe Tyre as a gateway and a center of trade (see Ezekiel 26:1–2). Both end with the same message: Tyre has come to a terrible end and will exist no more (compare Ezekiel 26:21).

Ezekiel 27:4–7

Tyre's former greatness is described in detail. The prophet uses the metaphor of a strong sailing ship.

This ship was built from the best materials of the surrounding nations. The image shows how wealthy and powerful Tyre once was.

Ezekiel 27:7

Elishah refers to part of Cyprus.

Ezekiel 27:8–9

Sidon, Arvad, and Gebal were towns on the Mediterranean coast.

Ezekiel 27:8–11

- The ship from Tyre had a crew of the world's most skilled men.
- The places listed in this section cover much of the known world at that time. This shows how wide Tyre's influence had spread.

Ezekiel 27:10

Persia, Lydia, and Put: Persia lay far to the east across land. Lydia was to the northwest, in what is now Turkey. Libya was to the southwest, along the Mediterranean Sea.

Ezekiel 27:11

- Helech is another name for Cilicia. This region was around Tarsus on the northeast shore of the Mediterranean Sea.
- The exact location of Gammad is not certain. It may have been in northern Syria.

Ezekiel 27:12

Tarshish was far to the west. Many scholars think it may have been located in present-day Spain.

Ezekiel 27:12–25

This large trading system existed to serve Tyre's strong desire for trade. The city wanted goods from many different lands and did not seem satisfied. The list of Tyre's trading partners is very long. Tyre traded in many kinds of goods, including slaves, horses, saddle blankets, silver, dyed cloth, and figs (compare Revelation 18:11–13).

The cargo list is arranged by geographic region. It names places from every direction (north, south, east, and west). It includes both large and small trading centers. Almost every valuable object that people could buy or sell appears somewhere on the list of Tyre's goods.

Ezekiel 27:13–14

Tubal, Meshech, and the nearby region of Beth-togarmah were located in Anatolia, an area that is part of modern-day Turkey.

Ezekiel 27:15

Dedan was a central Arabian oasis (see also Ezekiel 27:20). It might also refer to a coastal area north of Tyre.

Ezekiel 27:17

Minnith, located in Transjordan (the area east of the Jordan River), was a well-known source of wheat.

Ezekiel 27:18

Helbon was a town ten miles north of Damascus. Zahar may have been nearby, although its exact location is unknown.

Ezekiel 27:19

- from Izal: Izal (or Uzal) might have been a town in the foothills of Anatolia (a region in modern-day Turkey).
- Cassia and cane (or calamus) were costly perfumes.

Ezekiel 27:20–21

Kedar was a region of Arabia named for a son of Ishmael (Genesis 25:13).

Ezekiel 27:22

Sheba was a kingdom in southwest Arabia. The location of Raamah is uncertain, but it was always associated with Sheba.

Ezekiel 27:23

Haran, Canneh, Eden, and Asshur were all located in Mesopotamia. Mesopotamia is in what is now modern Iraq.

Chilmad is not mentioned anywhere else in ancient writings. Because of this, some scholars think the name may be a scribal error. A scribal error is a copying mistake made by a writer. It may have originally meant "all Media," a region northeast of Mesopotamia.

Ezekiel 27:26

The rich merchant ship seemed impossible to sink. It was loaded with valuable goods and appeared strong and secure.

But it could not stand against the strong east wind. This "east wind" represents the army of Babylon. The army would destroy Tyre, just as a powerful storm destroys a ship.

Ezekiel 27:36

Tyre's former residents and trading partners mourn the loss of its way of life. This section, like the previous one, ends by stating that Tyre has met a terrible end and will no longer exist (compare Ezekiel 26:21).

Ezekiel 28:1–19

- This section is the third message against Tyre (see study note on Ezekiel 26:1–28:19). It speaks directly to the ruler of Tyre, called the prince of Tyre. It condemns him for his pride.

The prince represents the city itself. What happens to him also happens to Tyre. In his pride, he claimed to be a god. He said that he sat on a divine throne and ruled over the powerful seas. But this was not true. He was only a man.

- This chapter and Isaiah 14, which speaks about the king of Babylon, are sometimes understood as describing a heavenly battle between God and Satan, who is called "the prince of demons" (Matthew 12:24). However, this interpretation overlooks the historical setting of these passages.

Tyre and Babylon were real cities. Their kings were real men. They had great power, but they were also very proud. The king of Tyre claimed to be a god, but his claim was empty.

Political powers that oppose God and his people may serve as agents of Satan in his struggle against God. Yet these rulers will fall. Their defeat points forward to God's final victory over all the powers of evil. Every authority that sets itself against the living God will be destroyed.

Ezekiel 28:3–5

The prince of Tyre claimed to be divine because of his wisdom and his wealth. He believed that his wisdom had made him very rich.

His riches then made him extremely proud. His pride grew out of his success and wealth.

Ezekiel 28:6–7

The prince of Tyre's pride led to his downfall (Proverbs 16:18). His claims of wisdom and power would prove empty when the Lord sent the Babylonian army against him. They would draw their swords and humble him.

Ezekiel 28:8

The clearest proof that the prince of Tyre was only a mortal man came when the Babylonians killed him. He would not rest in the heights with the gods, as he had claimed. Instead, he would go down to the pit, the place of the dead.

Like the city of Tyre, the prince would die in "the heart of the sea" (compare Ezekiel 27:26–27). This image means he would share the same complete destruction as the city.

Ezekiel 28:10

will die the death of the uncircumcised: In the Old Testament, circumcision was the sign of God's covenant (his special agreement) with Abraham and his descendants (compare Genesis 17:10–14). To be uncircumcised meant to stand outside that covenant relationship.

This warning means the prince of Tyre would die without any share in God's covenant promises. He would die as one who did not belong to the people of the covenant.

Ezekiel 28:12–19

At first, this funeral song seems to treat the prince of Tyre's claim to be divine as if it were true. It describes him as the model of perfection, full of wisdom and beauty.

But the tone is not sincere. The lament is sarcastic. It uses praise to expose his pride and to show how far he had fallen.

Ezekiel 28:13–14

- Ezekiel mocks Tyre's claim to great age and importance. He describes the king as if he had been in Eden at the beginning of the world. He presents him as a powerful angelic guardian. These heavenly

beings carried the Lord's throne in Ezekiel 1 and guarding the garden in Genesis 3.

In this picture, the king had access to the holy mountain of God. In the Bible, mountains are often linked with God's presence.

- The fiery stones may refer to shining gemstones around the garden of Eden. The list of jewels that the prince of Tyre supposedly wore adds to this image. It suggests he was specially chosen. The list includes nine of the twelve stones on the high priest's breastplate in Exodus 28.

This description mocks the prince's claim. It suggests that he believed he had a place even higher than Adam's. He claimed a place among the divine beings themselves.

Ezekiel 28:15–18

This sarcastic description of the prince of Tyre's greatness and pride sets him up for his fall, similar to the fall of humanity (Genesis 3). Like Adam, the king of Tyre's supposedly blameless state was temporary and ended abruptly when evil was found in him. His wealth and dishonest trade led him to violence (compare Ezekiel 26:17).

Someone who claimed to be greater than Adam could experience a similar fall from favor and be banished from the mountain of God, the place of God's favor. The prince of Tyre's God-given beauty and wisdom were corrupted by his pride, leading to disaster and revealing his true nature.

Ezekiel 28:18–19

The prince of Tyre was not a god who could make land holy. Instead, he made his sanctuaries unclean. Earlier, judgment was declared on his city. The prince of Tyre was destined to meet a terrible end and disappear (compare Ezekiel 26:21; 27:36). The proud leader would fall with his grand ship, reduced to nothing by the Lord's action.

Ezekiel 28:20–24

No specific charges are made against Sidon, Tyre's close neighbor to the north. However, it likely committed similar offenses. Its joy over Judah's destruction would not last.

Ezekiel 28:22–23

The Lord planned to show his glory and holiness through judgment. He would bring three kinds of punishment on Sidon:

- plague (disease),
- bloodshed, and
- attack by the sword.

The attack would come from every side. No part of the city would be safe.

Ezekiel 28:25–26

The Lord would not show his holiness only by judging nations for their pride, arrogance, and hostility toward his chosen people. He would also bring his people back to Israel. There, they would live safely, build homes, and plant vineyards. These were common signs of covenant blessings in the Old Testament (see Micah 4:4; Zechariah 3:10).

After God punished the neighboring nations and restored his people, they would find peace. The nations would recognize God as the Sovereign Lord through his powerful judgments, and Israel would know him as the Lord their God. This title reflects God's covenant relationship of worship and fellowship with them.

Ezekiel 29:1

This day in the tenth year since the exile of Jehoiachin was approximately one year after the beginning of the siege of Jerusalem.

Ezekiel 29:1–32.32

- The seventh and final message of judgment against the nations targets Egypt, an old enemy and ally of Israel. This message is the longest and, like the one against Tyre, it addresses both Egypt and its ruler.
- Egypt often tempted Israel and Judah to turn away from their loyalty to the Lord. Soon after leaving Egypt, Israel fell into the trap of Egypt's idolatry. Egypt led Judah to rely on chariots and horses instead of the Lord, but Egypt was unreliable when it mattered most. The Lord judged Egypt for leading his people astray (compare Luke 17:1–2).

Ezekiel 29:3–16

The message of judgment begins with a judgment against Pharaoh, who is called a great sea monster. In the ancient Near East, sea monsters were common in stories about the gods. These creatures represented chaos, which the gods had to control. In Genesis 1:21, however, sea creatures appear as part of God's good creation. They are not enemies of God.

In this chapter, the image changes slightly. The sea monster also reflects Pharaoh as a great crocodile. He rests confidently in the streams that flow through the Nile River delta.

Ezekiel 29:4–5

The image of the powerful crocodile leads to another image. The Lord will come like a great hunter.

Like Tyre, Egypt trusted in its watery defenses. But those waters would not protect it. The king of Egypt, who seemed strong and frightening, would be captured like an ordinary crocodile.

He would be dragged into the wilderness, which is a place of judgment. His allies are pictured as fish taken with him. There he would die. His body would be left in the open for wild animals and birds to eat.

Ezekiel 29:6–7

Egypt's sin is closely connected to Israel. Egypt is described as a staff made of reeds. A reed staff looks strong but breaks easily.

Egypt claimed it would support Israel, but it did not have the power or the will to help. It encouraged Israel to rebel against Assyria and Babylon but did not provide real help (compare 2 Kings 18:21).

Israel sinned by trusting in this weak support. But Egypt was also guilty. It gave false hope and would face God's judgment.

Ezekiel 29:8–13

God announced that he would destroy the land of Egypt. The land would become empty and ruined. The destruction would stretch from Migdol in the north to Aswan in the south. This means the whole land of Egypt.

Egypt would be empty for 40 years (compare Ezekiel 4:6). God would scatter the Egyptians among other nations. Later, he would bring them back to their land.

The Babylonians likely invaded Egypt in 568 or 567 BC. They took prisoners, who remained in exile until the time of Cyrus. This was about one generation later.

Ezekiel 29:14–16

Judah would one day be fully restored. Egypt, however, would return as a weak and unimportant kingdom.

Israel would no longer trust Egypt for help. Instead, they would learn to trust the Lord. Egypt's reduced position would remind Israel of its past mistake. They had trusted Egypt instead of trusting God.

Ezekiel 29:17–21

This message came in the twenty-seventh year of King Jehoiachin's captivity. This is the latest dated message in the book of Ezekiel. It is even later than Ezekiel's vision of the temple in Ezekiel 40–48.

Ezekiel 29:18–20

Nebuchadnezzar attacked Tyre (Ezekiel 26–28). His army worked very hard but gained little wealth from the city.

The Lord said that workers deserve their wages. So he would give Egypt to Babylon as payment for their work. Egypt would become their reward.

Ezekiel 29:21

- Even when God judged other nations, he still focused on his own people. As Egypt grew weaker, God would make Israel strong again.
- I will cause a horn to sprout for the house of Israel: A horn was a common symbol of strength and dignity (see Psalm 132:17; compare Daniel 7:7–8; 8:3). This means that God would restore Israel's strength and dignity.

This restoration would also show that Ezekiel was a true prophet. Ezekiel had served the Lord faithfully. At times, people may have doubted him. In the end, they would see that his message was true.

Ezekiel 30:1–19

This third message against Egypt is written as a lament (a poem of sorrow). It repeats much of the earlier message in Ezekiel 29:1–16.

God would judge Egypt and its allies. The nation would fall under his judgment.

Ezekiel 30:6–7

From Migdol to Syene: This phrase means "from north to south." See study note on Ezekiel 29:8–13.

Ezekiel 30:12

I will make the streams dry up: God said he would dry up the Nile River. Egypt depended on the Nile for water, farming, and trade. If the river dried up, the people could not survive or prosper.

Ezekiel 30:13–14

God would destroy Egypt's main cities. Memphis was the most important city in the north. Thebes was the most important city in the south.

Ezekiel 30:14

- Zoan, now called Tanis, was in the eastern Nile delta. It was near the area where the Israelites once lived as slaves.
- Thebes was the sacred city of the god Amon. It was the capital of Upper Egypt. Upper Egypt was in the south because it was farther up the Nile River.

Ezekiel 30:15

Pelusium was a fortress town on Egypt's northeastern border.

Ezekiel 30:17

of On and Pi-beseth: These cities were located in the Nile delta.

Ezekiel 30:18

- Tahpanhes was a fortress town on Egypt's northeastern border.
- darkened: Egypt's light would turn to darkness when God judged it. This recalls the plague of darkness during the exodus (Exodus 10:21–23).

Ezekiel 30:19

After this judgment, the Egyptians would recognize the Lord's power. This happened before at the time of the exodus. Even those who do not worship the Lord must finally admit that he is real and powerful.

Ezekiel 30:20–26a

This fourth message shows that God had already begun to act against Egypt.

Ezekiel 30:20–26b

Jerusalem was under attack by Babylon. Some people hoped that Egypt would help Jerusalem. God said this would not happen. Egypt could not save them.

Ezekiel 30:21–23

broken the arm of Pharaoh: The Lord had already weakened the Egyptians' power when Nebuchadnezzar defeated Pharaoh Hophra (see Jeremiah 37:5–11). If Hophra had succeeded, Jerusalem would have had temporary relief.

Now, all hope for help from Egypt was gone. There was no chance for the broken arm to heal or even be temporarily supported, so Pharaoh could not protect Jerusalem. Egypt would be completely helpless, unable to wield a sword as it awaited its final defeat.

Ezekiel 30:24–26

While weakening Pharaoh (Ezekiel 30:22), the Lord would strengthen the arms of Babylon's king, making the contest even more uneven. The Lord controlled the fate of the upcoming battle between the superpowers and had already decided its outcome. Nebuchadnezzar fought the Egyptians several times, ending with victory in 567 BC.

Ezekiel 31:1–18

Ezekiel asked the Egyptians to compare themselves to Assyria, which was like a great tree in Eden (Ezekiel 31:9). If that tree was cut down and sent to the underworld, how could Egypt, whose glory was less than Assyria's, believe it could survive?

Ezekiel 31:2–4

- The cedar of Lebanon was a tree known for its beauty and great value. People used its wood for building, trade, and even military purposes.
- Assyria is compared to a tall cedar tree. Its army had once been stronger than any other army. Like a tree whose top reaches the clouds, Assyria's power seemed greater than all others.

Ezekiel 31:6

Like a great tree, Assyria provided shelter for all of the birds and wild animals of the earth. This tree was more magnificent than all the trees in the garden of God, the garden of Eden. It had a God-given beauty and stature similar to the prince of Tyre in Ezekiel 28. Assyria's power was so great that all the great nations of the world lived under its influence.

Ezekiel 31:10–11

- Egypt forgot that God created her beauty, and she became proud and arrogant. Like Tyre, such pride would lead to a fall. The God who placed Egypt in a high position would send a powerful nation to destroy it, as its wickedness deserved.
- I have banished it: The human agent would only be carrying out what God had already decided.

Ezekiel 31:12–14

Egypt's judgment would teach the other nations an important lesson. No matter how powerful they believed themselves to be, they would all one day die and go down to the Pit (the place of the dead).

Ezekiel 31:15

- The mourning for the great tree, Assyria, was as great as the tree itself. Its fall brought deep sorrow.

- The tallest cedar trees in the ancient world grew in Lebanon. These trees were known for their great height and strength.

Ezekiel 31:16–17

The nations trembled with fear when Assyria fell. Other great nations had already fallen and gone down to death. They were pleased when Assyria joined them in defeat. Assyria's allies also followed the same path and shared in its destruction.

Ezekiel 31:18

The main message of this long comparison now becomes clear.

Egypt was strong and glorious. However, it would be destroyed just as Assyria had been. It would also share in the shame of other nations that trusted in their own power and greatness.

Ezekiel 32:1

In the twelfth year, on the first day of the twelfth month: This event happened two months after the exiles in Babylon learned about Jerusalem's fall (see Ezekiel 33:21).

Ezekiel 32:2–3

- Ezekiel compares Pharaoh to a powerful beast (Ezekiel 29:3).
- Egypt's pharaohs used the lion and a monster in the seas (or crocodile) as symbols of strength. These animals represented power and control. However, both lions and crocodiles can be hunted and killed. The same would happen to Pharaoh.

God would act through his chosen agents (Ezekiel 32:11–12). They would hunt Pharaoh, capture him, and drag him away.

Ezekiel 32:4–6

mountains ... valleys ... mountains ... ravines: In Hebrew, this is a literary device called a merism (a way of naming the outer parts to include everything in between). It shows both the boundaries and all that lies within them. Here, it emphasizes that God's judgment would cover the whole land.

The description of destruction uses hyperbole (intentional exaggeration). This strong language shows that Egypt's defeat would be complete.

Ezekiel 32:7–8

As in the previous chapter, Pharaoh's downfall would bring global darkness and widespread mourning. These images were often linked to the day of the Lord (see Joel 2:30). In this case, the darkness would also remind the Egyptians of the plague during the exodus (Exodus 10:21–22).

Ezekiel 32:9–10

The nations around Egypt and their kings would be filled with fear when Egypt fell. They would worry that the same judgment might come upon them.

Ezekiel 32:11–12

The human instrument of God's judgment was the sword of the king of Babylon. He was coming to break Egypt's power completely and permanently.

This destruction would be greater than what happened at the first Passover. At that time, only the firstborn sons of Egypt and the firstborn male animals died (Exodus 12:29). This time, the judgment would be far more severe.

Ezekiel 32:14

The great sea monster (Ezekiel 32:2), a picture of Pharaoh, would no longer struggle in the river and stir up the mud like an angry crocodile.

After Pharaoh's death, the waters of Egypt would become calm again. They would flow smoothly and quietly, like oil poured out. The land would be silent and still, like the quietness that follows death.

Ezekiel 32:15–16

This complete destruction of Egypt would lead them to recognize the Lord's power, just like during the exodus.

Ezekiel 32:17–32

This final message against Egypt brings the whole series of messages to a close. It gathers together the main themes from God's judgments against all the nations.

Ezekiel 32:18–20

In an earlier message (Ezekiel 31:17–18), God said that Egypt would go down to join other nations in the place of the dead. Here that idea is explained more fully.

Egypt would share the fate of those who were rejected and those killed by the sword. They would go to the Pit, a word that describes the place of the dead.

This place of judgment was already filled with many nations. These nations were once powerful, but they had fallen and been destroyed (compare Isaiah 14:9–11).

Ezekiel 32:21–30

Assyria ... Elam ... Meshech and Tubal ... Edom ... the leaders of the north and the Sidonians: In the past, these nations filled people with fear. Now they are described as weak shadows of what they once were. Their power is gone, and they exist in a place without joy or purpose.

Assyria had been defeated by the Babylonians and the Medes between 627 and 609 BC. After that time, it was no longer a great world power.

Ezekiel 32:31–32

Pharaoh and all the power of Egypt would share the same fate as these other nations.

For a time chosen by God, Pharaoh caused fear among the nations. But when God decided to act, Egypt's power was broken completely and permanently.

Ezekiel 33:1–48.35

After the judgment messages in Ezekiel 1–24 and the messages against the nations in Ezekiel 25–32, Ezekiel describes the future renewal of the land, the covenant, the people, and the unity of Israel and Judah under new leadership.

Ezekiel 33:2–4

watchman: See study note on Ezekiel 3:16219. The message about the watchman is part of Ezekiel's public announcement, not a private task. It emphasizes that the listeners are responsible for acting on the watchman's message.

Before Jerusalem's destruction, people ignored the warning. After the exile, they struggled to believe the message of hope. In both situations, Ezekiel faced rejection and was tempted to stay silent. God warned him again that he could not.

Ezekiel 33:5–9

Ezekiel's message urged the people of Israel to repent so they could live. The Lord had warned of an army coming against their country, and this was happening. Ezekiel had been faithful as a watchman. No one who heard his prophecy could say he did not warn them of the coming judgment. But the people did not listen to the warning. If they did not turn away from their sin and return to God, they would die in their sins.

Ezekiel 33:10–11

our sins are heavy upon us ... How can we live?: At last, the people of Israel began to take the prophet's warnings seriously. However, there was now a new danger. Instead of turning to God in repentance and faith, they might fall into despair.

God's judgment is not like an unchangeable fate. It still allows room for forgiveness. The Sovereign Lord does not take pleasure in the death of wicked people.

Even those who have done great evil can live. If they repent (turn away from their sin) and change their ways, they will live.

Ezekiel 33:12–16

The principle in Ezekiel 33:10–11 is explained through two examples.

The first example concerns righteous people. Some trust in their past good behavior to save them. But later they turn to sin. God says he will judge them for their present sin, even if they once lived righteously. Their past obedience will not protect them if they now reject what is right.

The second example concerns wicked people who repent. If they turn away from their evil actions and begin to do what is just and right, God will forgive them completely. No matter what they did in the past, they will live if they truly change.

This teaching repeats an earlier message. In Ezekiel 18, the people said they were suffering because of their parents' sins. Here, they seem to say something different. They think their parents' sins have placed the nation under a permanent curse. Because of this, they believe repentance is useless.

Ezekiel 33:17–20

- The way of the Lord is not just: People thought it was wrong for God to use Babylon to destroy Jerusalem. The Lord quickly corrected this idea (Ezekiel 33:18).
- their way that is not just: The people's mistake was refusing to repent and accusing God of being unjust.
- I will judge each of you according to his ways: The Lord's judgment is never random but matches their sins. If they repent, trust the Lord for salvation, and act justly and rightly, they have hope for the future (compare Ephesians 2:8–10).

Ezekiel 33:21

A survivor came from Jerusalem, bringing an eyewitness account of the city's fall. It took over five months for this news to reach the exiles.

Ezekiel 33:22

The news that Jerusalem had fallen marked a turning point for Ezekiel.

His ability to speak returned (see Ezekiel 3:26; 24:25–27). He was now free to speak openly to the people.

This change also brought new hope for God's people.

Ezekiel 33:23–26

Those who stayed in the ruined cities of Judah saw the Exile as a chance for personal gain, not repentance. They claimed to be the only heirs of Abraham's promise and sought to own all the land. Their actions showed they were not truly Abraham's children. They ignored laws against eating meat with blood (see Deuteronomy 12:23), worshiped idols, and killed innocent people. Their lives denied Abraham's faith, and they would not inherit his promise.

Ezekiel 33:23–33

People in Judah (Ezekiel 33:23–29) and those in exile (33:30–33) continued to act as they had before Jerusalem fell.

Ezekiel 33:27–29

The rebels in Jerusalem would continue to face the curses of the Mosaic covenant (violence, wild animals, and disease; see Leviticus 26:22–25). This would happen until the mountains of Israel were empty and these sinners were completely destroyed.

Ezekiel 33:30–33

The situation was not much better among the exiles in Babylon.

Many of them talked about Ezekiel's messages. They discussed what he said, but they did not change their attitudes or behavior. They were no different from the people still living in Judah.

They would sit in front of Ezekiel and appear sincere. However, they did not plan to obey what the Lord told them. They treated his messages as something pleasant to hear.

But the Lord warned them that, in time, the truth would be clear. Events would show that the words of a true prophet carry God's power.

Ezekiel 34:1–24

This chapter includes both judgment and salvation. God would judge the shepherds, that is, the former kings of Judah. They failed to care for their flock, meaning the people of Judah.

The Lord would also judge the fattened sheep. These were the strong and selfish people who harmed others. Yet God would act as a good shepherd. He would care for the rest of the flock and provide for them.

The image of the shepherd shows both the strength and kindness of God's actions with His people. In the ancient Near East, a shepherd was a common symbol for a king. People saw the earthly king as a representative of the divine shepherd who appointed him.

Shepherds had to protect their flocks from wild animals like lions and bears. They also needed to know their sheep by name and gently lead them to good pasture and calm waters. They faced cold, heat, wind, rain, and snow while caring for their flocks.

Good kings who led their people wisely and strongly were like shepherds. The New Testament uses the same image to describe pastors and elders, who should oversee their flock without being domineering (1 Peter 5:2–4). Jesus perfectly combines strength and kindness as the "great Shepherd of the sheep" (Hebrews 13:20).

Ezekiel 34:1–37.28

These chapters describe the blessings that would come when the Lord returned to his people.

He would be their shepherd. He would give them good and faithful leadership (Ezekiel 34).

He would make the land fruitful again. In this way, he would show that his name is honored and holy (Ezekiel 35–36).

He would bring his people back to life and make them one nation again (Ezekiel 37).

Ezekiel 34:2–6

Woe to the shepherds: Israel's leaders did not care for the weak or search for those who wandered away and were lost. They pursued their own interests, feeding themselves at the flock's expense. They ruled the sheep with harshness and cruelty, similar to how the Egyptians treated the Israelites in the time of Moses (Exodus 1:13–14). The neglect and abuse by these cruel shepherds scattered the Lord's flock across the earth.

Ezekiel 34:7–11

The Lord promised to hold the selfish shepherds accountable for their actions. He would remove them from their positions and save his flock from their

grasp, so they would no longer be prey. The Lord would search for his scattered flock (Ezekiel 34:12) and bring them home.

Ezekiel 34:12–16

The dark and cloudy day, the day of judgment (compare Ezekiel 32:7–8), was over. Now God would bring his people back to the mountains of Israel, the center of the land promised to the patriarchs, and care for his sheep (see Psalm 23).

Ezekiel 34:17–19

The goats were the powerful, unrighteous members of the community.

Ezekiel 34:20–22

the fat sheep and the lean sheep: People with power and influence took all the good things for themselves, leaving others without resources. God will judge them and make things right.

Ezekiel 34:23–24

one shepherd, My servant David: God had promised to raise up a descendant of David to rule after him (2 Samuel 7:12–16). This "new David," like the first, would serve the Lord. He would be faithful to God and lead the people well. He would care for them like a good shepherd cares for his sheep.

Ezekiel 34:25–26

God promised to give his people a new and better ruler. He would also make a covenant of peace with them.

At that time, they were suffering from wild animals, drought, famine, and war. These troubles were the result of breaking the covenant God made at Mount Sinai (see Leviticus 26:14–35).

From then on, they would live in safety. They would camp without fear. God would send the rain they needed so the land would produce crops. They would enjoy peace and the blessings of the covenant (see Leviticus 26:4–13).

Ezekiel 34:27–31

In this covenant of peace (a promise of restored relationship with God), God's people receive the blessings that come from being whole in their relationship with him. This covenant was not completely new. It was like the covenant God made at Mount Sinai.

The Sinai covenant promised true and lasting peace. However, the people did not experience that peace because of their sin. They broke their relationship with God again and again.

In the past, Israel's kings failed to lead the people well. In this new covenant, God would give them a new and perfect king. The broken relationship with God would be restored.

God's people would again belong to him. They would be like sheep who belong to their shepherd. The covenant would reach its goal when the Sovereign Lord was their God and lived among them once more.

Ezekiel 35:1–15

This message of judgment is directed to Edom, Israel's neighbor to the southeast. It is also called Mount Seir, the main mountain region of Edom.

Edom stands as a symbol of all Israel's enemies. For example, Edom rejoiced when Israel fell (Ezekiel 36:2; see also 25:12–14).

When Babylon destroyed Judah, Edom may have thought it had a chance to grow stronger. However, the Lord said that its success would not last long.

Ezekiel 35:5–10

The ancient hatred of Edom for Israel began with their ancestors, Esau and Jacob (see Genesis 25:19–34; 27:1–46; Numbers 20:14–21; 24:18; 2 Samuel 8:13–14; 1 Kings 11:14). Because of this hatred, the Edomites took advantage of Babylon's destruction of Jerusalem. They attacked the Israelites when they were weak and helpless. They tried to destroy the descendants of Jacob and take the lands of Israel and Judah.

The Edomites enjoyed killing the Israelites. But the violence they brought on others would return to them. Their own people would die by the sword. God would punish their lasting hatred. Their land would become empty and ruined forever.

This prophecy came true in the 400s BC. During that time, a group of Arab tribes forced the Edomites out of their land.

Ezekiel 35:13–15

The Edomites wrongly thought that God's judgment on his people and his leaving the temple meant his covenant with Israel had ended. The Edomites boasted and elevated themselves above both Israel and the Lord.

The God of Israel would not allow such boasting, for he is the ruler of all. His choice of Israel and his gift of the land to them would not be taken back.

Ezekiel 36:1–15

The destruction of Edom (chapter 35) would prepare the way for the restoration of the mountains of Israel, reversing the devastation threatened in chapter 6.

Ezekiel 36:2

Israel's ancient high places (the hill country and mountains) could not be taken by their enemies. The Lord had given this land to his people.

Ezekiel 36:6–7

The period of enduring the shame of mockery and plundering would now be over for Israel, and Israel's enemies would soon endure their own shame by being mocked and plundered.

Ezekiel 36:8–11

When God's people returned to their land, Israel would grow in number and in harvest. This would fulfill the command God gave at creation to "be fruitful and multiply" (Genesis 1:28).

Ezekiel 36:12–13

God intended the land to provide plenty for his people and their children. Instead, it took their children and consumed its own people. This happened because Israel did not follow the covenant, leading to the Lord's judgment with disastrous effects for them and their children (see Ezekiel 5:17). Now that the people were changing, they would receive the covenant blessing of a fruitful land.

Ezekiel 36:16–38

- Ezekiel reminded the people of their guilt and their need for God to change their hearts. In the future, God would cleanse his people.
- In the Old Testament, objects and people are divided into "clean" and "unclean," "sacred" and "profane" categories (see "Clean, Unclean, and Holy" Theme Note).

God made Israel clean, but the Gentile nations remained unclean. Israel became unclean due to bloodshed and idolatry, which defiled the land. Because they acted like unclean nations, it was fitting for Israel to be scattered among them as punishment. In the future, God would make them clean so he could dwell among them again. Other nations, seeing his holiness in his people, would know he is the Holy One.

In the New Testament, God's redemption through Christ redefines the lines between clean and unclean (see Acts 10:15). The Gentiles are no longer outside of God's grace. They, too, can receive the Holy Spirit and become clean. Jews and Gentiles together now form the one people of God in Christ.

Those in Christ Jesus are not only clean but also holy because of his priesthood. Therefore, they can come boldly into God's presence and experience his grace (Hebrews 12:18–29).

Ezekiel 36:17

- Covenant curses came to Israel because the people defiled their land through sinful behavior.
- A menstrual cloth became polluted by contact with a woman's monthly blood flow. This natural process was not sinful, but it made people ceremonially unclean. Any loss of bodily fluids, like blood, sweat (see study note on Ezekiel 44:17–19), or semen, also caused ceremonial uncleanness (see Leviticus 15).

Ezekiel 36:18

Israel made the land unsuitable for God's presence by committing murder and worshiping idols. Because they broke their covenant, they were expelled and scattered among the nations (see Deuteronomy 29:22–28).

Ezekiel 36:20

This scattering also brought shame to the Lord's holy name. It was not the exiles' behavior that took away the Lord's glory. Instead, their exile made other nations think Israel's God could not protect them in their own land.

Ezekiel 36:21–24

God sent Israel into exile because he cared about his holiness. He wanted to protect the honor of his holy name, so he planned to bring them back to their land. Israel did not earn this return from exile; it showed the Lord's holiness and power to other nations. Israel could not stay outside the land God promised to Abraham and his descendants forever.

Ezekiel 36:25

Bringing Israel back to the land was not enough. They would also become a new, transformed Israel. God would sprinkle them with clean water to cleanse them from all impurities that had defiled the land. Such sprinkling with water was a routine part of Jewish pu-

rification ceremonies (see Numbers 19). It symbolized a fresh start, with their old sins washed away.

Ezekiel 36:26

The Lord's renewal of his people would not be only an outward cleansing. He would give Israel a new heart and a new spirit (Ezekiel 11:19; 18:31).

In the Bible, the heart and spirit refer to a person's inner thoughts and will, which guide actions. Their stubborn and resistant heart would become soft and responsive. They would be ready to serve the Lord.

Their spirit of rebellion would be replaced with a spirit of obedience.

Ezekiel 36:27–28

The spirit of God would bring life and light from darkness and chaos (see Genesis 1:2). This would give people a new ability to follow God's rules and regulations.

In the past, God's Spirit empowered individuals for specific tasks in service to the Lord (see Judges 3:10; 1 Samuel 16:13).

In the future, God's Spirit would empower more people to live holy lives (see Joel 2:28–29). These renewed people would live in Israel, making it suitable for God's presence to dwell among them again.

Ezekiel 36:29–32

This change would bring the blessings of the covenant made with Moses, not its curses, and new honor among nearby nations. This blessing would make God's people deeply regret their past and recognize both their unworthiness and God's immense kindness.

Ezekiel 36:35–38

The restored land would become like the garden of Eden, a symbol of fertility and fruitfulness. The original garden would be enhanced by restored cities, filled with people like Jerusalem's streets during festivals. The greatest blessing would be God's willingness to hear Israel's prayers again.

He had once refused to listen to his rebellious people (Ezekiel 14:3; 20:3), but now the Lord would turn his face toward them and hear their cries. The proof of this would be the number of people in the rebuilt cities who would acknowledge that the Lord is God.

Ezekiel 37:1–14

The prophet saw a lively city full of life (Ezekiel 36:38). Then, he found himself in a valley filled with bones. This symbolized the promise that the spirit of the Lord gives life (Ezekiel 36:16–38).

Ezekiel 37:2

This death scene seemed hopeless. These were not recently dead bodies, but scattered bones, completely dried out. This scene symbolized the people's attitude. Their hopes were not just dead. Their hopes were broken and dried up.

Ezekiel 37:3

Son of man, can these bones come to life?: The expected answer was no, but Ezekiel knew that God's power is unlimited. So, he asked God the question again. The real issue was not if the Lord could make these bones live, but if he wanted to do so.

Ezekiel 37:4–6

- God wanted these bones to live. He communicated this through the message that Ezekiel was to deliver to the bones. Ezekiel declared they would become living, breathing bodies again, with flesh, muscles, and breath.
- The word translated as breath can also mean "spirit" or "wind," a wordplay that continues throughout this chapter.

Ezekiel 37:7–8

Ezekiel followed his task to prophesy to the bones, and they formed complete bodies. However, a body with bones, muscles, flesh, and skin is still lifeless. These people needed breath to live, as described in Genesis 2:7.

Ezekiel 37:9–10

When Ezekiel spoke to the four winds, breath entered the re-formed bodies. They stood up as a great army ready for action. This breath, symbolizing being filled with the Spirit, gave them life and strength for action, just as it had happened to the prophet on two earlier occasions (Ezekiel 1:28–2:2 and 3:23–24).

Ezekiel 37:11–14

The oracle that follows explains this vision. The people in exile felt as lifeless as old, dry bones. They believed all hope was lost. However, the Lord could and would restore them to life. God would call them his people again. He promised to open their graves of exile and bring them back to the land of Israel.

Ezekiel 37:14

The Lord would give his life-giving Spirit to his people. If the sovereign Lord decided to raise them, their dryness would not stop him.

Ezekiel 37:15–28

The prophet then performed a sign action (see "Prophetic Sign Acts" Theme Note) that showed the future reunification of God's people and the healing of the division between the northern and southern tribes (see 1 Kings 12).

Ezekiel 37:19

The Lord, who has complete authority and power, would bring Israel back together by his own power.

Ezekiel 37:20–25

When the kingdoms were joined together again, the problems that had caused the division would also be solved.

In the past, King Rehoboam's harsh and unfaithful leadership divided the nation (1 Kings 12). Now God would give his people one servant leader, a shepherd king. Like David, this king would unite the tribes.

The restored people would also be made clean again. God would remove their idols and other sinful practices. The Lord would once again be their God.

After being made pure, they would obey the Lord's laws and live in the land forever.

Ezekiel 37:25–28

The covenant of peace is the blessing that comes from obeying the covenant. This covenant would last forever.

In the past, the people's sin made them unclean. Because of this, the Lord allowed the temple to be destroyed. Now their new purity would be shown in a new sanctuary. God would live among them there forever.

This final temple would show the success of God's work to make his people holy. It would demonstrate that the Lord is the one who makes Israel holy (see Ezekiel 40–48).

Ezekiel 38:1–6

Gog would lead a group of seven nations from all over the world. The numbers seven and four symbolize completeness, showing an unbeatable alliance from every direction. Magog, Meshech, Tubal, Gomer, and Beth-togarmah were in the north, in Anatolia and beyond the Black Sea. Persia was to the east, Ethiopia to the south, and Libya to the west.

Ezekiel 38:1–39.29

- In Ezekiel 37, the nation is reunited and lives in peace in its own land. In Ezekiel 38–39, this peaceful picture changes. A new danger appears. These chapters describe the attack, defeat, and removal of the final enemy, called Gog.

Many readers have tried to identify Gog. Some have connected him with Gyges, king of Lydia, who ruled about 680 to 644 BC. However, the Gog described in the Bible goes beyond any one historical ruler. The text focuses less on who Gog is and more on the worldwide threat from the nations.

Even this powerful enemy would not truly threaten God's restored people. God was now living among them. Because of his presence, they were secure.

These chapters use strong symbols. They are similar to psalms that speak about Zion's safety (see, for example, Psalms 2, 46). The message is clear. If even a terrible enemy like Gog cannot defeat God's people, then nothing in all creation can separate them from God's protection.

- Ezekiel's description of Gog also includes features of apocalyptic literature (a style of writing that uses symbols and dramatic images to describe God's final victory over evil; see "Apocalyptic Literature" Theme Note).

Ezekiel 38:4

Gog's rebellion would remain fully under God's control.

Gog and his army would think they were acting freely and attacking on their own. In reality, God would control their actions. They would be like prisoners led away with hooks in their jaws (compare Ezekiel 29:4).

Ezekiel 38:8

After a long time (literally after many days) ... In the latter years (literally in the end of the years): This battle is described as a final and climactic conflict. It would come before a lasting time of peace.

Some people believe this battle will be a real event at the end of history. Others believe it is a symbolic picture (a literary image) that shows how the Lord protects his people in every age. In this view, the battle represents the ongoing struggle between God's people and evil.

Whichever view is correct, the main message is clear. When the Lord's favor rests on his people, nothing can remove them from his protection. Not even the strongest and most complete attack of evil can defeat them.

Ezekiel 38:9

advancing like a thunderstorm: This is similar to the threatening imagery in Ezekiel 1, when God was Israel's enemy. At that time, Israel sought protection from the rebellious nations around them. Now, Israel would seek protection from God against the nations.

Ezekiel 38:10

The Lord's "hooks" in Gog's "jaws" (Ezekiel 38:4) refers to Gog's evil plan to attack the defenseless Israelites and steal their goods (compare Psalm 76:10).

Ezekiel 38:13

The trading nations of the world would gather to profit from Gog's expected victory.

Sheba and Dedan were in the east. Tarshish was in the west. Merchants from these distant places would come to buy and sell the goods taken in battle.

They believed that Gog and his allies would surely win. They expected to gain wealth from the spoils of war.

Ezekiel 38:14–16

Israel would be prosperous, living in peace and enjoying the benefits of trusting in the Lord. However, such trust does not remove the chance of facing threats (compare John 16:33). The situation might have seemed unfavorable for Israel, but Gog did not consider the Lord's power. The Lord would use Gog and his allies to show his holiness to all nations.

Ezekiel 38:17

Gog was not the foretold "army … from the land of the north" mentioned in Jeremiah 4–6. Those prophecies had already been fulfilled. They referred to the destruction that King Nebuchadnezzar of Babylon brought against Judah.

Ezekiel 38:18–20

Gog would face divine wrath instead of causing it. The Lord would unleash on Gog the jealousy and anger once directed at Israel. The scene would be so terrifying that even innocent bystanders would shake with fear. The earth would tremble, destroying mountains, cliffs, and walls.

Ezekiel 38:21–23

sword … plague and bloodshed … torrents of rain, hailstones, fire, and sulfur: Israel had faced similar punishments before (see Ezekiel 13:13). Now those punishments were inflicted on Israel's enemies. The divine warrior was once again defending his people.

Ezekiel 39:2

I will turn you around, drive you along: The Lord will bring Gog against Israel to defeat him.

Ezekiel 39:3–4

This terrible enemy, Gog, would be left helpless after his defeat.

His dead body would become food for vultures and wild animals. This was similar to what happened to Goliath (compare 1 Samuel 17:44–46).

Ezekiel 39:5–6

Gog's homeland would be destroyed.

The harm that his armies and his allies had planned for others would fall back on them. Those who felt safe would suffer the same destruction they had intended for others.

Ezekiel 39:7–8

God's judgment on Gog will reveal his holy name. He once judged his own people for their sins to protect his reputation (Ezekiel 36:16–20). Now, he will defend his restored people and judge their enemies.

Ezekiel 39:9–10

Israel would act only after Gog had been fully defeated and destroyed. Like some great battles in the past, the people would first watch the Lord fight for them. Then they would gather what was left behind (for example, 2 Kings 6:1–7:20; 2 Chronicles 20).

Fire from heaven would destroy Gog's army. Only their wooden weapons would remain. Israel would use these weapons as firewood for seven years. In the Old Testament, the number seven often represents completeness.

Those who came to take goods from Israel would themselves be taken as goods. The attackers would lose everything. Their weapons would no longer be needed, because Israel's final enemy had been destroyed.

Ezekiel 39:11

The people needed to collect the plunder and bury the bodies of the dead soldiers. If left unburied, these corpses would defile the holy land, as touching a corpse made a person ritually unclean. There were so many bodies that they required a large graveyard, big enough to fill an entire valley, which would become known as the Valley of Hamon-gog.

Ezekiel 39:12–16

So many people would die that all Israel would take part in cleaning the land for seven months.

Even after those seven months, more work would remain. Specially appointed workers would continue to search the land. When they found human bones, they would mark the place so the remains could be buried properly.

Ezekiel 39:17

God would also gather birds and wild animals to remove the dead bodies.

This is described as a great sacrificial feast. The animals would feed on those who had been defeated.

Ezekiel 39:18–20

In most sacrificial feasts, people eat animals that have been offered as sacrifices.

In this feast, the situation is reversed. Animals would eat the bodies of defeated enemies, as if they were rams, lambs, goats, and bulls.

This scene is the opposite of the great banquet described in Isaiah 25:6. In that future feast, God's people are invited to celebrate. Here, God's enemies become the meal instead of the guests.

Ezekiel 39:21–24

The Lord will show his glory throughout history.

He showed his glory when he punished Israel during the exile. This punishment came because of their sin and their uncleanness.

Ezekiel 39:25–29

God would also show his glory by bringing his people home from exile in the lands of their enemies.

After he had fully carried out his judgment for their sins, he would gather them again. He would not leave even one person behind.

He would pour out his Spirit on the people of Israel. His Spirit would change them so they would not repeat their former sins. He would never again turn away from them.

God's future favor toward his people was certain (compare Romans 8:31–39).

Ezekiel 40:1–46.24

The prophet's tour of the new temple began outside the building. He then moved step by step toward its center.

After reaching the inside, he walked outward again. The tour ended at the kitchens located in the corners of the outer courtyard (Ezekiel 46:19–24).

Ezekiel 40:1–48.35

The final section of the book of Ezekiel describes a new temple and a new division of the land.

First, Ezekiel describes the new temple (Ezekiel 40:1–47:12; see "Temple Architecture as Theology" Theme Note; "Temple Legislation as Theology" Theme Note). This vision includes detailed plans for the building and its rules. It also shows how the temple's design and laws teach about God.

Next, Ezekiel describes how the land will be divided among the tribes of Israel (Ezekiel 47:13–48:35; see "Israel's Geography as Theology" Theme Note). This section shows that even the geography (the way the land is arranged) has meaning.

The temple stands at the center of the land. This central place shows that God himself is at the center of his people. The temple is the final and most important part of God's plan to restore (bring back and renew) and sanctify (make holy) his people. God promises that he will once again live among them (see Ezekiel 37:28).

Ezekiel saw this temple in a vision. However, the people of Israel never built this exact temple in history.

Ezekiel 40:2

a very high mountain: In the Old Testament, God often revealed himself on mountaintops. Moses received God's law and the design for the tabernacle at Mount Sinai (Exodus 19–40). He also viewed the promised land, which he would never enter, from the top of Pisgah (Deuteronomy 34:1–4). Similarly, on this mountaintop, Ezekiel met with God and saw the wonderful future God had prepared for his people, even though he would not live to experience it.

Ezekiel 40:3

a man whose appearance was like bronze: An angelic guide would lead Ezekiel's tour of the temple. The

bronze color reminds us of the heavenly creatures described in the first vision (see Ezekiel 1:7).

Unlike the guide for his earlier vision of the earthly temple in Ezekiel 8–11, this guide carried only a linen measuring cord and a measuring rod. These are tools for building, not destroying.

Measurement is a key theme in the following chapters. It allows the prophet to emphasize the importance of certain parts of the temple by making them larger and more precisely defined than other parts.

Ezekiel 40:5

a wall surrounding the temple area: Walls create and define space, marking an "inside" and an "outside." This wall was important. Its function was to separate the "profane" [unholy] area outside the temple from the holy area inside. This ensured the important distinction would never again be forgotten (see Ezekiel 22:26).

Ezekiel 40:5–16

The exact architectural details of the temple are difficult to translate. Some of the building terms are hard to understand in every language. However, the overall impression of these gates is clear.

The gates looked like fortresses (strong buildings used for defense). They were built to keep out people who did not have permission to enter. These gates protected the holy space of the temple.

The eastern gateway is described first because it was the most important. It stood on the sacred east–west line (a straight line from east to west) on which the whole temple was built. This gateway is also important because the glory of the Lord (God's visible and powerful presence) would return through it (Ezekiel 43:1–5).

Ezekiel 40:7

Six guard alcoves (small rooms for guards) lined the inside of each gate. There were three on each side. This design shows that the gates had a defensive purpose.

The layout of these gates was similar to gates found at Hazor, Megiddo, and Gezer. Archaeologists have uncovered gates like these in those cities. However, the temple gates in Ezekiel's vision were much larger than the ones found there.

Ezekiel 40:16

The carved palm trees remind readers of the rich plant life of the garden of Eden. Palm trees were a sign of life and fruitfulness (that is, the ability to grow and produce food). Similar carvings appear in the temple described in 1 Kings 6:29.

Ezekiel 40:17–19

The outer courtyard formed a buffer zone (a space that protects another space) around the holy things in the inner courtyard. This open area separated common space from the most sacred space. In this way, it helped guard what was holy.

Thirty rooms were built along the walls of the outer courtyard. The text does not clearly state the purpose of these rooms. It also does not give their exact measurements. This lack of detail increases the contrast between the less important outer area and the central holy space, which receives much more attention.

These rooms were most likely used by the Levites. The Levites were members of the tribe of Levi who served in temple worship. They probably used these rooms for different tasks related to their service.

Ezekiel 40:20–27

The north gateway and the south gateway are described in similar ways to the east gateway. However, the description gives fewer details than it does for the east gateway. Even so, these gates were strong and impressive structures.

Like the east gateway, they served as a powerful defensive barrier. They were meant to prevent any defilement (anything unclean or impure) from entering the sacred area.

There was no west gateway to either the outer court or the inner court. The area behind the main temple building was closed off. This design prevented anyone from entering the temple area from the rear.

Ezekiel 40:22

Steps led up to each gate. These steps made the gates feel less accessible. A person had to go up in order to enter the sacred area.

The inner parts of the temple were higher than the outer parts. The more sacred the space, the higher it stood. This difference in height created another level of separation between common space and holy space.

In this way, the design of the temple showed that not every place was the same. Some areas were set apart as more sacred than others.

Ezekiel 40:28–34

The inner courtyard was divided from the outer courtyard by another set of large gateways. These gateways were similar in size and purpose to those of the outer courtyard. The entry rooms of these gateways faced outward toward the outer courtyard, unlike the outer gates, where they faced inward.

Ezekiel 40:35–37

The text does not mention a wall around the inner courtyard. This may be because the inner court stood higher than the outer court. It was raised by another eight steps, which may have been about 2.4 meters (about 8 feet) high.

If there were no wall, there may have been a free-standing archway (an open structure shaped like an arch). This design would allow people to see what was happening inside. At the same time, the height would prevent anyone from stepping into the sacred area by accident.

Another possibility is that the text simply does not mention the wall. The writer may have left out that detail, even if a wall was present.

Ezekiel 40:38–43

The sacrificial animals were killed and prepared in rooms beside the gateways that led into the inner courtyard. This detail shows the main purpose of the new temple. It was a place for sacrifice.

The animals had to be washed and cut into pieces before the priests offered them on the altar. These steps prepared the animals for worship.

In Ezekiel's vision, this new temple strongly focuses on sacrifices that atoned for sin. These sacrifices dealt with sin and restored the relationship between God and humanity that sin had broken. By contrast, the temple in Jerusalem was both a place for sacrifice and a house of prayer (see 1 Kings 8:27–30, 52–53; Isaiah 56:6–8; Matthew 21:13).

Ezekiel 40:43

The hooks might be used to store the knives and tools mentioned in Ezekiel 40:42.

Ezekiel 40:46

The Lord finally rewarded Zadok's loyalty (see Ezekiel 44:15). He decreed that only Zadok's descendants could approach the Lord to serve him. Only those chosen by the Lord and fit to enter the holy space could access God in this temple.

Ezekiel 40:47

The themes of sacrifice and limited access come together in the description of the inner courtyard's size. It was a perfect square, a common shape for holy spaces in the Old Testament (see Exodus 26:1–35; 1 Kings 6:20), measuring 175 feet on each side. At its center stood the altar of sacrifice, the only piece of furniture there. People had to offer holy sacrifices without risking impurity to ensure the Lord's presence when he returned to fill the temple with his glory.

Ezekiel 40:48–41.3

The temple stood at the protected center of the temple complex. It was next to the inner court. This location showed its importance.

The temple also stood at the highest point in the complex. It was ten steps higher than the inner court. The inner court itself was eight steps higher than the outer court. This rising height showed increasing holiness as a person moved inward.

Like Solomon's temple before it, this temple had three main areas. These were:

- the entry room,
- the sanctuary (the main holy room), and
- the Most Holy Place (the most sacred room).

Ezekiel 40:49

Outside the entry room were square columns with an unknown purpose, similar to those in Solomon's temple (1 Kings 7:15–22).

Ezekiel 41:1–2

The temple walls were about 3.2 meters thick (10.5 feet). These thick walls showed strength and protection. At this point, the gates were replaced by a doorway. Only the priests were allowed to enter the inner court around the temple, so a heavy gate was not needed.

The sanctuary was the most important room in the new temple. For this reason, the vision describes it in greater detail than the other rooms. It also gives more exact measurements for this space.

Ezekiel 41:3–4

The inner room was the Most Holy Place. It was the only square room in the temple. This room was the most sacred space in the building.

A person reached it by passing through three openings. Each opening was narrower than the one before

it. Access became more limited as a person moved closer to God.

The entrance to the entry room was about 7.5 meters wide (24.5 feet; Ezekiel 40:48). The doorway into the sanctuary was about 5.3 meters wide (17.5 feet; 41:2). The entrance to the Most Holy Place was only about 3.2 meters wide (10.5 feet).

Ezekiel did not enter the Most Holy Place. He stood outside and waited while the angel went in alone and measured the room.

Ezekiel 41:5–26

The temple had 90 side rooms on three levels. Behind it was a large building with an unknown purpose, possibly to prevent unauthorized access. No one could approach God's presence from behind. The side rooms might have stored priestly clothing and equipment.

Ezekiel 41:15–20

The temple building was covered with wooden panels. The walls were decorated with carvings of palm trees and cherubim.

The cherubim were like those Ezekiel saw in his earlier visions of judgment (see Ezekiel 1:5–12; 10:2–14). In those visions, the cherubim had four faces. However, the carved images in the temple had only two faces. One face was a lion, the greatest of the wild animals. The other was a human, the highest part of God's created order.

Cherubim also decorated Solomon's temple (1 Kings 6:32). Cherubim were traditional symbols of judgment. The palm trees were traditional symbols of blessing. Together, these images showed both God's judgment and his blessing.

Ezekiel 41:22

The only piece of furniture was a wooden altar, the table that stands in the Lord's presence. This is likely where the priests daily placed the bread of the presence before the Lord (Exodus 25:30). Describing this table as an altar emphasizes the focus on sacrifice in Ezekiel's temple.

Ezekiel 42:1

Ezekiel reached the center of the temple complex and then started moving outward again.

Ezekiel 42:3–12

The priests' rooms were on three levels at the back of the sanctuary. Priests entered from the top level in the inner court (Ezekiel 42:12) and exited at the bottom in the outer court (42:9). These rooms served as transition spaces for the priests' duties as they moved between the inner and outer courts.

Ezekiel 42:13–14

The priests stored and ate the most sacred offerings in these rooms. They also kept their holy clothes there. When not serving in the Lord's presence, the priests changed into other clothes because the holy clothes were special. These rules show more care in separating the holy from the ordinary compared to similar laws in Leviticus (see Leviticus 6).

Ezekiel 42:16–20

After finishing his tour of the inner courtyard, Ezekiel saw the overall dimensions of the area. The entire complex was square, symbolizing holiness. This shape set it apart from Solomon's Temple and the tabernacle, where only the Most Holy Place was square. The description of the temple ends where it started, mentioning a wall surrounding it (see Ezekiel 40:5). Ezekiel reminds us that the wall's purpose was to separate the holy from the common.

Ezekiel 43:1–4

The sacred spaces mentioned earlier were useless when empty (see Ezekiel 37:7–8). The temple needed the presence of the God of Israel's glory to be meaningful. This glory had left in Ezekiel 10. Now, it would return from the east, the same direction it had left. Unlike its slow and hesitant departure, its return would be sudden, with the loud roar of rushing waters (see Ezekiel 1:24; Revelation 1:15). As usual, the prophet fell face down in awe of this glory.

Ezekiel 43:5–7

The Spirit took Ezekiel to the inner courtyard. There, he heard the Lord say that the restored temple was his palace, with his throne and footstool. He would live there forever among the people of Israel.

Identifying the temple as God's dwelling and seat of power was not new (see, for example, 1 Samuel 4:4). The temple would now be God's throne forever. The sins of his people would never again drive him away from his sanctuary.

Ezekiel 43:7–9

If God were to remain with his people, they needed higher standards. They also needed clear rules to prevent the sins of the past from happening again.

In earlier times, Israel and their kings dishonored God. They worshiped other gods. They also honored dead kings by placing memorial markers inside the temple area. The temple belonged to the living God, not to human rulers.

In the future, the proper order would be restored. The home of the earthly ruler would be placed farther from the spiritual center of the land (see Ezekiel 45:7). This change would show clearly that God alone was supreme.

Placing the earthly ruler in his proper position was necessary. Only then could God remain among his people forever in his rightful place.

Ezekiel 43:10–11

At this point, God explained the purpose of the temple vision. Ezekiel was not the first person to receive a detailed plan for a sanctuary from God (see Exodus 25–40).

This vision was not meant to begin a future building project after the people returned to their land. Instead, it was a message for the people living in Ezekiel's own time.

As they carefully studied the plan of the temple, they were meant to recognize their sin. They were to feel deep sorrow and shame for what they had done.

As they looked at the entrances and exits, the laws and commands, and the full design, they should see how far they had turned away from God. The vision was meant to lead them to repentance (turning away from sin and back to God).

Ezekiel 43:12

Israel had to be completely holy if the holy God was to live among them forever.

Ezekiel 43:13–16

The holiness of the temple area would be protected in two ways. First, sinners were kept out of the sacred space. Second, the sacrificial system dealt with sin and impurity.

This focus on holiness is clear from the detailed description of the altar in the inner court. The altar stood at the center of the entire temple complex. Its central place shows how important it was.

The altar shown to Ezekiel was much larger than the altar in front of the tabernacle. It was almost three times as long and wide (see Exodus 27:1–8).

Ezekiel 43:17

Steps led up to this altar from the east side. Normally, in the ancient Near East, steps came from the west. This change might have been to avoid any suggestion of sun worship (see Ezekiel 8:16).

Ezekiel 43:18–21

- The new altar had to be consecrated (set apart for holy use) before it could be used.
- On the first day, the priests were to offer a young bull as a sin offering. They were to put its blood on the horns and corners of the altar. This act made the altar ready for holy service.

After this, they burned the body of the sin offering outside the sacred area. This was the same practice used with the tabernacle (compare Leviticus 4:11–12).

Ezekiel 43:25

They repeated the second day's procedure for seven more days to finish the eight-day purification cycle. They used a similar method when they consecrated Solomon's Temple (2 Chronicles 7:8–9).

Ezekiel 43:26–27

These sin offerings made the temple ready for holy use. The priests could once again sacrifice the burnt and peace offerings of the people. These offerings were necessary if the Lord were to accept his people.

Ezekiel 44:1–31

Now that the glory of the Lord had returned to the temple, access was critical. Who could approach this holy God? Like Ezekiel 43, this chapter focuses on the temple's entrances and exits, as well as the duties and procedures for its use.

Ezekiel 44:2

The outer east gate must always stay closed because the Lord has returned to his temple and will never leave it again. He made this gate holy by passing through it, so no one else should use it.

Ezekiel 44:3

The prince had the special privilege of being the only one allowed to feast in the Lord's presence inside the east outer gateway. However, he could only enter and leave the portico from the outer court. He was not to enter from outside the temple complex through the gate, as the Lord had. The earthly ruler is a man, not God, and he must submit to God. The prince must also

remember that the temple is God's palace, not his own private chapel.

Ezekiel 44:6–8

The people of Israel were called rebels because they did not control access to the sanctuary. They hired uncircumcised foreigners as temple guards and gatekeepers. The Levites should have done this job, as the Lord assigned it to them (compare Ezekiel 44:10).

Ezekiel 44:9

No foreigner: This was not a complete ban on non-Israelites entering the sanctuary. It only applied to those who were uncircumcised and had not dedicated themselves to the Lord. True converts could join the new Israel (see Ezekiel 47:22–23).

Ezekiel 44:10

when Israel went astray, and who wandered away from Me after their idols: The people often turned away from the Lord and worshiped idols instead. They did not keep the instructions God had given them for temple worship.

One specific example was the use of foreigners as temple guards (Ezekiel 44:8). God had given clear directions about who should serve in the temple. By ignoring these instructions, the people showed their unfaithfulness.

Ezekiel 44:12–14

- The Levites had led Israel into serious sin. The people turned away from the Lord and worshiped idols.

Because of this sin, the Levites could no longer enter the inner court of the temple as the priests did. This was one result of their disobedience. However, God still showed them grace. They would continue to serve by helping the people and by killing the animals offered as sacrifices.

- The people as a whole were now kept at a greater distance from God because of their idolatry. Before the exile in Babylon, they killed their own sacrifices(see Leviticus 1:5, 11). Now they had to give the animals to the Levites, who would kill them on their behalf.

Ezekiel 44:15–16

Unlike the Levites and others who turned to idols, the Levitical priests from Zadok's family stayed loyal to the Lord.

Zadok was the high priest during Solomon's time. His family was rewarded with access to the inner courtyard to perform important sacrifices closer to God.

These chapters often highlight that those who were faithful in the past would be rewarded with closer access to God and more privileges, while the unfaithful would remain farther away.

Ezekiel 44:17–19

- The priests had special access to God. Because of this privilege, they also had greater responsibility to live in holiness. Their behavior was more restricted than that of the people.

They had to wear linen clothing instead of wool. This helped prevent sweat, which would make them ritually unclean (see study note on Ezekiel 36:17). They also had to keep separate garments that were used only for sacred service.

- transmit holiness to the people with their garments: The priests had to be careful not to endanger others by passing on holiness. In the Old Testament, holiness was understood as something that could spread through contact. If a sacred object made an ordinary object or person holy, serious consequences could follow (compare Leviticus 10:1–3; 1 Samuel 6:19; 2 Samuel 6:6–7).

Ezekiel 44:20–27

The priests had to avoid contact with death. They could not enter a place where a dead body was present. They also could not follow certain mourning customs, such as shaving their heads or letting their hair grow wild.

They were not allowed to drink wine before entering the inner courtyard. This rule helped prevent serious mistakes that could lead to death (see Leviticus 10:9).

The priests also had rules about marriage. They could marry only a virgin from Israel or the widow of a priest. These limits helped protect the purity of the priestly family line.

In all these ways, the priests were to show the people the clear difference between what was holy and what was common, and between what was clean and what was unclean.

Ezekiel 44:28–30

The priests belonged to the Lord and received support from a share of the temple's sacrificial offerings. They did not own land or property. The Lord was their inheritance. The people supplied their needs with the firstfruits of harvests and various temple offerings.

Ezekiel 44:31

They could not eat any bird or animal that died naturally or was attacked by another animal because they separated themselves from death.

Ezekiel 45:1–8

Ezekiel 47–48 describes how the restored promised land was divided among the tribes. This section focuses on the central sacred area, which included land for the priests.

The exiles were eager to regain land, as they had none. Ezekiel's goal was not just to ensure fair land distribution. He wanted to remind them of the promised land's true purpose. It was a place where God would live among his people. Therefore, the central part of the land was assigned to the Lord as his holy portion. This created a zone of holiness and protection around the temple.

Ezekiel 45:3–4

Within this holy portion, the temple complex would form the Most Holy Place at the center of a sacred square. Like the Most Holy Place in the temple, which was protected by an inner court for priests only, the temple complex was also surrounded by a section reserved for priests.

Ezekiel 45:5–6

To the north of this priestly strip was an area reserved for the Levites; to the south (48:15).

Together, these areas formed a square. Each side was about 13.4 kilometers long (8.3 miles).

Ezekiel 45:7

On both sides of the larger sacred area (Ezekiel 45:1–6), the rest of the holy portion was given to the prince. The same pattern of limited access that applied in the temple also applied to the land around it. Not everyone had the same level of access to the holy space.

The temple would be the geographic and spiritual center of the new Israel. The land would be divided into sections that ran from east to west. This layout arranged the whole nation around the temple's east–west line.

The city and the prince would still have important roles. However, they would no longer stand at the center. The Lord himself was Israel's true King. His dwelling place would be the center of their life as a people.

Ezekiel 45:8–9

A clear sign of the Lord's rule was giving land to both the prince and the people. The prince received enough land to meet his needs and support the temple's ministry without oppressing or robbing the people.

Ezekiel 45:10–12

When the prince collected the people's offerings for the temple (see Ezekiel 45:13–17), he should not alter the scales to gain from the difference between what he received and what he provided for the temple's ministry.

Ezekiel 45:13–17

The people had to pay a tax to the prince for daily offerings at the new temple. The prince provided offerings for special occasions like religious festivals, new moon celebrations, and Sabbath days. Both daily and special offerings purified the people of Israel, making them right with the Lord.

Ezekiel 45:21–25

Like the offerings, the annual festivals in the new temple were meant to purify the people and the land. Instead of the three main festivals of the time of Moses (the feasts of Passover, Harvest, and Tabernacles), there were now only two. These two, Passover and Tabernacles, were almost the same and took place six months apart.

The Passover festival still happened on the fourteenth day of the first month. It was similar to the earlier Passover in many ways, but it required many more sacrifices than those listed in Numbers 28. The Feast of Tabernacles is not directly named in the Hebrew text. It no longer had special customs or symbols, except that the prince offered the same sacrifices as he did for Passover. This festival still took place in the seventh month.

Throughout these descriptions, a main theme becomes clear: the land must be kept pure and free from sin.

Ezekiel 46:1

The east gateway between the inner and outer courtyards opened weekly for the Sabbath, monthly for new moon celebrations, and when the prince offered voluntary burnt or peace offerings (Ezekiel 46:12). The east gate between the outer courtyard and the outside world was never to open again (Ezekiel 44:2–3).

Ezekiel 46:1–15

Ezekiel described the prince's duties during special celebrations, including Sabbaths and new moon events. The prince represented the people in worship. He joined them in a procession through the temple and had the unique ability to approach the sacred area for them.

Ezekiel 46:2

The prince had the special privilege of entering the eastern gateway to the inner courtyard up to the entry room for worship. This showed that God saw him as more important than the common people. However, he still needed the priests to mediate for him to stand in God's presence.

Ezekiel 46:3

The ordinary Israelites, the common people, could climb the stairs to the threshold to worship when the gate was open on the sabbath and the first day of the month. Only then could they see into the inner court. Otherwise, they had to stay away from it.

Ezekiel 46:9–10

During religious festivals, the people would present themselves before the Lord. They would walk through the temple from north to south or south to north, with the prince among them. They moved along the ordinary north-south path, not the sacred east-west path used by the priests.

Ezekiel 46:12

The voluntary burnt offering or peace offering was in addition to the daily offerings of meat, grain, and oil. These offerings symbolized the restored relationship and fellowship between God and his people.

Ezekiel 46:16–18

The land given to the prince was a gift from the Lord to him and his family. Because of this, he could not give it away permanently to one of his servants.

In the Year of Jubilee, which came every fiftieth year, all land in Israel returned to its original family owners. In that year, any land given by the prince would return to him and his family.

This rule helped prevent the king from taking more and more land to reward his servants. Without this limit, ordinary people could lose their land.

The land belonged to the Lord. He divided it among his people. No one, not even the king, could change or take away the inheritance that God had given.

Ezekiel 46:19–24

The vision of the temple proper (Ezekiel 40–46) ends where the tour started. The prophet began in the outer court. He traveled to the center and back out twice, finishing at the outer court's edges, in the kitchens. Here, people cooked various sacrifices. Some sacrifices were burned completely on the altar. Others were only partially burned, with parts returned so the worshiper could feast with his family in the Lord's presence.

Ezekiel 47:1

- The stream's source was inside the temple.
- from under the south side of the temple, south of the altar: In Solomon's Temple, this spot held the Sea, a large bronze pool for cleansing water (1 Kings 7:23, 39). The Sea also had symbolic meaning. In the ancient world, the sea often represented chaos (disorder and danger). By placing the Sea in the temple, it showed that God had power over chaos within his ordered world.

In Ezekiel's vision, the Sea is no longer a still pool. Instead, it becomes a flowing river that gives life. This image recalls the river in Eden (see Genesis 2:10–14; Psalm 46).

Ezekiel 47:1–12

Once the temple was restored to its central place among God's people, its life-giving influence would flow outward.

Ezekiel pictures this influence as a river. As the river moves away from the temple, it brings change. It turns places of death into places of life.

Ezekiel 47:3–5

At first, the stream was only a small trickle flowing from the temple gate. As it moved farther away, it grew deeper and deeper. Soon it became too deep to walk through.

The exiles needed this reminder. God often begins his work in small and quiet ways. Over time, what seems small can grow into something full and powerful by God's action.

Ezekiel 47:6–9

As the river flowed, it became deeper and wider. It brought life wherever it went. Even the salty waters of the Dead Sea became fresh and full of life.

Ezekiel 47:10

From En-gedi on the west side of the Dead Sea to En-eglaim on the east side, the Dead Sea would change from death to life.

The Dead Sea is filled with salt and other minerals. Because of this, nothing can live in it. In Ezekiel's vision, the river would make its waters fresh. The sea would be filled with many kinds of fish. There would be enough fish to support a large fishing industry.

Ezekiel 47:11

The valuable salt deposits from the Dead Sea area would remain intact. The marshes and swamps would still contain salt.

Ezekiel 47:12

Along both sides of this river of life, fruit trees of every kind will grow. Like the righteous person described in Psalm 1, their leaves will not wither. They will produce fruit at the right time.

These trees will be so full of life that they will bear a new crop every month. Their leaves will have healing power. The river will bring real and visible blessings to all of God's people.

Wherever this river flows, life will appear.

Ezekiel 47:13–48.35

The final section of the book of Ezekiel describes the boundaries of the land and how it will be divided among the tribes.

In this section, theology (teaching about God) is shown through geography (the arrangement of the land). The way the land is organized has meaning. Matters such as space, access, and position in relation to the temple are very important.

Where a tribe lives, and how close it is to the temple, shows something about order and holiness among God's people.

Ezekiel 47:15–20

The new promised land's boundaries were similar to those in Numbers 34:1–12. The boundaries stretched from Lebo-hamath in the north to the Brook of Egypt in the south, and from the Mediterranean Sea in the west to the Jordan River in the east.

The people would now fully possess this promised land, which they had never done before. Transjordan, the area east of the Jordan River, was not included. This area was the historic home of Reuben, Gad, and half of the tribe of Manasseh. It was outside the boundaries promised to Moses and was not part of the original promise. But many Israelites had lived there in the past.

Ezekiel 47:21–23

The land within these borders was to be divided among the tribes of Israel.

In the past, before the exile, the nation was divided into two kingdoms. In the future, there would be one united kingdom. The twelve tribes would live together as one people.

This new arrangement would also include resident foreigners. If these foreigners had joined Israel as converts (people who had turned to worship the Lord), they were to receive a share of the land. They would receive an allotment just like native-born Israelites. They could also pass this land on to their children.

For Ezekiel, the land had deep meaning. It was a sign of God's promise and blessing. Because of this, receiving a share of the land was a great privilege.

Ezekiel 48:1–8

The land given to the tribes was divided into long strips that ran from east to west. Before the exile, the land had been divided in smaller and uneven sections. This new arrangement was orderly and balanced.

This plan did more than give each tribe equal access to land and resources. It also matched the sacred east–west pattern seen in the temple. In the temple, the layout followed a clear east–west direction. The land was now arranged in a similar way.

The central sacred area was carefully measured and clearly defined. The outer areas were described with less detail (see study note on Ezekiel 40:17–19).

The four tribes farthest from the holy area were Dan, Asher, Naphtali, and Gad. These tribes were in the least honored position. They were descended from the sons of Jacob by Zilpah and Bilhah, the servant women of Leah and Rachel.

The eight sons born to Leah and Rachel received land closer to the holy portion. Their strips lay directly

north and south of the sacred area that included the temple.

The tribes closest to the holy portion were Benjamin and Judah. In earlier history, these tribes surrounded Jerusalem. Judah's land was placed just north of the holy portion. In the past, the kingdom had been divided into north (Israel) and south (Judah). In this new arrangement, Judah was placed in the north, showing a restored and reordered people.

Ezekiel 48:9–14

- The holy portion was not exactly in the center of the land. There were seven tribal strips to the north and five to the south. Although not centrally located, the spiritual center had moved significantly north from Jerusalem.
- The importance of the holy portion for the Lord's temple is emphasized by its detailed dimensions and composition, unlike the brief descriptions of the tribal areas.

This special portion was dedicated to God and could never be sold, traded, or used by others. It consisted of strips running from east to west, given to the Levites, the priests, and the city. The area for the ordained priests surrounded the temple, protecting it from anything unholy. An area for the Levites was to the north.

Ezekiel 48:15–20

To the south was a narrower strip of land set apart for public use. The city was located there.

Together with the surrounding sacred areas, the central section formed a square.

The city served as a visible sign of unity for the 12 tribes. It was home to residents from many different tribes. In this way, it showed that all the tribes belonged to one people.

Ezekiel 48:21–29

The land that lay to the east and west of the holy square completed the rest of the central area. This land was assigned to the prince.

The prince held a higher position than the rest of the people. However, he was below the priests and the Levites in rank and responsibility. His place in the land showed this order.

The design of the temple complex taught the same lesson. The arrangement of space showed clear levels of authority and holiness.

Ezekiel 48:30–31

At the end of the book, Ezekiel describes the exits of the city. He again emphasizes the theme of access, which appears throughout Ezekiel 40–48.

Like the temple, the city was a square with exact measurements. It had 12 gates, one for each tribe of Israel. This design showed that all the tribes were united as one people.

Three gates were especially important. They were named after Reuben, Judah, and Levi. Reuben was the oldest son of Israel. Judah was the royal tribe, from which kings came. Levi was the priestly tribe, set apart for temple service.

These three important gates faced north, not east as one might expect. The north side was most important because it faced the temple, the center of the restored land. The south side was second in importance because it also aligned with the temple.

Ezekiel 48:32–34

The gates that faced east were assigned to the children of Rachel. These tribes were Joseph and Benjamin. Dan was also included, since he was born through Rachel's maidservant.

The gates on the south side were assigned to Simeon, Issachar, and Zebulun. These were sons of Leah. Their lands would lie south of the holy square.

The gates on the west side were assigned to Gad, Asher, and Naphtali. These tribes descended from the maidservants Bilhah and Zilpah. The west side was considered less favored in this arrangement.

Ezekiel 48:35

To complete the vision, the city received a new name: THE LORD IS THERE. The Lord had once left Jerusalem and ordered its destruction due to idolatry and violence. Now, the new city was part of a new order and could bear this name. This change meant the violent city from earlier chapters was now a holy city, suitable for God to live among representatives of all 12 tribes of Israel (compare Isaiah 4:2–6; Zechariah 14:20–21).

So, the prophecy in Ezekiel 37:26–27 reaches its conclusion and fulfillment. God places his sanctuary among his people forever, just as he promised.